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BRIJ BHUSHAN ASSAULT CASE

Vinesh says she is a complainant in case

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OPEC+ hikes oil production quotas

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COURSE OF ACTION

Govt. issues childhood diabetes care norms

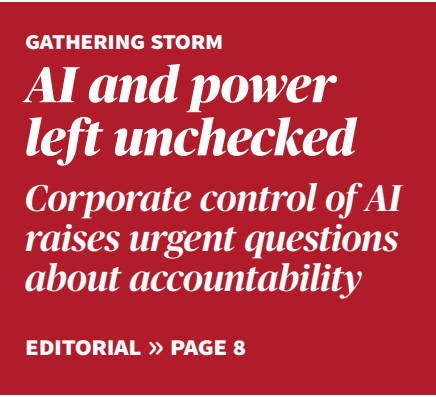
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GATHERING STORM

AI and power left unchecked

Corporate control of AI raises urgent questions about accountability

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RULING THE DAY

Titans, Knight Riders register victories

SPORT » PAGE 15

U.S. choices are impossible operation or bad deal: Iran

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran's Revolutionary Guards on Sunday said the United States faced a choice between an "impossible" military operation or a "bad deal" with Tehran.

Negotiations between the two countries have been deadlocked since a ceasefire came into effect on April 8, with only one round of direct peace talks held so far.

Iran's Foreign Ministry said Tehran had submitted a 14-point plan "focused on ending the war" and that Washington had already responded to it in a message to Pakistani mediators.

"We are reviewing this and will take whatever response is necessary regarding it," spokesperson Esmaeil Baqaei told state television.

Mr. Trump, however, had already dismissed the offer.



I will soon be reviewing the plan that Iran has just sent to us, but can't imagine that it would be acceptable in that they have not yet paid a big enough price for what they have done to Humanity, and the World, over the last 47 years

DONALD TRUMP
U.S. President

"I will soon be reviewing the plan that Iran has just sent to us, but can't imagine that it would be acceptable in that they have not yet paid a big enough price for what they have done to Humanity, and the World, over the last 47 years," Mr. Trump said on his Truth Social platform.

U.S. news website Axios reported that the proposal set "a one-month deadline for negotiations on a deal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, end the U.S. naval blockade and permanently end the war in Iran and in Lebanon".

In a statement on Sun-

day, the Revolutionary Guards sought to put the onus back on Mr. Trump, saying he must choose between "an impossible operation or a bad deal with Iran".

The day before, Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi told diplomats in Tehran that "the ball is in the United States' court to choose the path of diplomacy or the continuation of a confrontational approach".

Iran, he said, was "prepared for both paths".

SLEEPLESS IN TEHRAN
» PAGE 14

Parties brace for verdict; EC promises transparency

Heavy security as counting of votes polled for elections to the Assemblies of Assam, Kerala, T.N., West Bengal, Puducherry, and bypolls to seven Assembly seats in five States will be taken up today

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

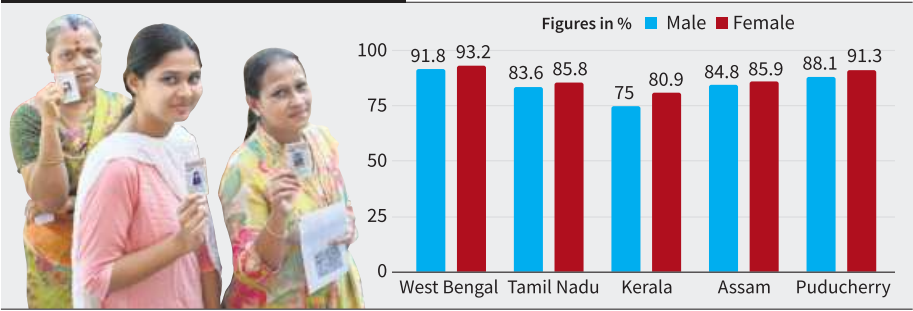
The Election Commission on Sunday said it would uphold the "highest standards of transparency, security and efficiency" when votes polled in the elections to the Assemblies of Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, and Puducherry and the bypolls in seven Assembly constituencies in five States are counted on Monday.

For West Bengal, the EC had deployed 165 additional counting observers to assist counting observers and 77 police observers to conduct "a secure, peaceful, intimidation-free, and transparent environment".

Exuding confidence, the political parties and fronts are watching the counting

Eyes on the count

The chart shows the gender-wise poll participation in the four States and one Union Territory



preparations closely.

In Assam, the Congress-led front of six parties hopes to shed the Opposition tag by preventing the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) from scoring a hat-trick of wins. Both the alliances are confident about bagging at least 64 seats, the majority mark in the 126-member Assembly. While the Chief

Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma-helmed BJP has predicted close to 100 seats for the NDA, the Gaurav Gogoi-steered Congress is confident of a similar number for the Asom Somilito Morcha to return to power after 10 years.

With just hours left for the counting of votes polled in the April 9 election, Kerala's voter turnout

was updated provisionally to 79.7% on Sunday as election officials factored in 20,028 postal ballots of service voters polled till May 1. The leaderships of all three fronts were confident about the results.

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RELATED REPORTS ON
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Breaking the ice



Paving the way: Ahead of the opening of Gurdwara Sri Hemkund Sahib in Chamoli district of Uttarakhand, Army personnel clearing snow from its premises on Sunday. The Hemkund Sahib yatra is scheduled from May 23. PTI

Nine dead as major fire rips through residential building in East Delhi

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Nine people were killed in a major fire in a residential building at Shahdara in East Delhi in the early hours of Sunday. Fifteen people were brought to safety by rescue teams. Five of the dead were from one family.

The fire was reported around 3.48 a.m. in the building in the Vivek Vihar Phase I residential complex. Eyewitnesses said the fire broke out on the ground floor, likely from an air-conditioner, and quickly spread to the three floors above. Delhi Fire Service (DFS) officials said the blaze was brought under control around 6.25 a.m. Two of the residents had injuries. Several of them were taken to a nearby



Family members of victims mourn after nine people were killed in a fire at Vivek Vihar in East Delhi on Sunday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

hospital, while the search continued through the morning. Most of them were discharged immediately, officials said.

"The search-and-rescue and firefighting operations were carried out simultaneously. The building comprises a basement, a stilt, and four upper floors

spread across an area of over 7,000 sq. ft. There are two flats on each floor [one in the front of the building and the other in the rear]. The rear side was enclosed with grilles which caused problems in the rescue," Mukesh Verma, Duty Officer, DFS, said.

Expressing grief, Prime

Minister Narendra Modi announced *ex gratia* for the kin of the dead and the injured.

Bodies recovered

As the search operation ended, the DFS and the police confirmed the recovery of nine charred bodies — one from the first floor, five from the second floor, and three from a locked staircase on the third floor. The upper ground floor was empty.

While most of those residing in the flats on the front side were rescued, those on the rear side were affected the most. The deceased belonged to three families. Authorities said they are probing to ascertain the cause of the fire.

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Passenger from Sharjah detained after he opens emergency exit door, runs on tarmac after landing

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A passenger arriving in Chennai from the United Arab Emirates caused a flutter when he opened the emergency exit door and ran on the tarmac on Sunday. As a result, an international flight reaching the city was diverted to Bengaluru.

Uses evacuation slide

An Air Arabia international flight from Sharjah landed at the Chennai airport around 3.45 a.m. As the aircraft was taxiing, the passenger opened the emergency exit door, came out



Freak incident: It took nearly an hour to close the slide. The aircraft was brought to the bay around 4.45 a.m. and the passengers disembarked. IMAGE USED FOR REPRESENTATION PURPOSE ONLY.

through the evacuation slide, and ran on the tarmac towards gate no. 102, airport sources said.

Air Traffic Control offi-

cials, who noticed the incident, raised an alert. Personnel of the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) rushed to the spot

and caught the passenger. He was handed over to the police. It took nearly an hour for the aircraft team to close the evacuation slide. Around 4.45 a.m., the aircraft was brought to the bay, and the passengers disembarked, airport sources said.

Probe launched

Officials of the Airports Authority of India (AAI) said they had begun an investigation.

As the flight was held up on the runway for nearly an hour, an international flight arriving from London was diverted to Bengaluru.

The Greater Chennai Police identified the passenger as Mohamed Najmudeen Sherif, a native of Pudukkottai district. He said he was travelling with a group of eight persons, and he had opened the emergency exit door to escape, as he feared someone was plotting to attack him. He was detained at the airport. Officials questioned the passenger as well as those who had travelled with him.

Later in the day, the police said the passenger was found to be under mental stress, and was admitted to a hospital for evaluation and treatment.

Nepal raises Lipulekh issue; India says no 'historical' record

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri's upcoming visit to Nepal came under a shadow on Sunday with Nepal expressing "concerns" to both India and China over the next season of Kailash Manasarovar Yatra through the Kalapani-Limpiyadhura-Lipulekh region. It reiterated that the region is part of Nepal's sovereign territory.

In response to Kathmandu's remarks, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said that Nepal's claims on the Lipulekh Pass are not based on "historical facts".



Vikram Misri

The Ministry had announced on April 30 the next round of Kailash Yatra would take place in coordination with China in June-August.

Earlier, Mr. Misri's plans to visit Kathmandu were in focus because of uncer-

tainties in securing a meeting with the new Prime Minister, Balendra Shah, who has refused to meet foreign envoys as he has been following a restrictive diplomatic protocol since taking charge in March.

In an announcement, Nepal's Ministry of Foreign Affairs said, "The Government of Nepal is completely clear and steadfast in the fact that Limpiyadhura, Lipulekh and Kalapani east of the Mahakali river are integral parts of Nepal since the Treaty of Sugauli of 1816."

CONTINUED ON
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INBRIEF



Man found dead in Velliangiri Hills in Coimbatore district

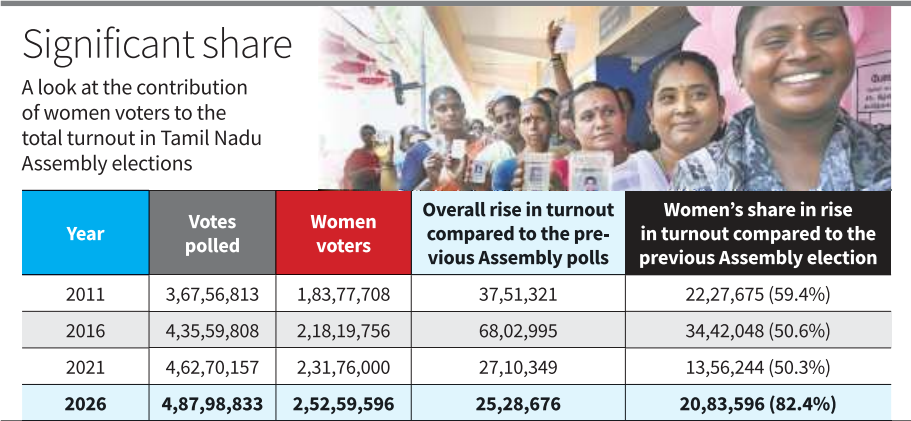
A man aged between 35 and 40 was found dead in the Velliangiri Hills in Coimbatore district on Sunday morning, taking the toll of persons who died during the ongoing annual pilgrimage season to seven. According to the Forest Department, pilgrims found the man lying unconscious on a rock at the seventh hill around 3.30 a.m. The Forest Department could not identify the deceased as he did not carry identification cards or a mobile phone. The man wore a purple t-shirt and blue shorts. The Forest Department suspects the deceased trekked the hills alone as no one has approached the staff with complaints of a missing pilgrim.

Perumal Murugan, Medha Patkar to receive award

Social activist Medha Patkar and Tamil writer Perumal Murugan have been selected for the Sukumar Azhikode Birth Centenary National Award, according to a release from the Sukumar Azhikode Trust. The award recognises their exceptional contributions to society and literature and includes a cash prize of ₹50,000 along with a citation. Ms. Patkar is being honoured for her lifelong commitment to social activism, particularly her work advocating for the rights of displaced communities. Mr. Murugan is recognised for his significant impact on Indian literature and his bold exploration of complex social issues. The award will be presented at Kannur on May 12.

Women make up over 80% of the additional voters in 2026 polls

Of about 25.3 lakh more votes polled this time than in 2021, around 20.8 lakh came from women, the highest in the last four Assembly elections



T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

For the first time in the last four Assembly elections in Tamil Nadu, women have accounted for over 80% of additional voters in 2026. Of about 25.3 lakh more votes polled this time than in the 2021 election, around 20.8 lakh have come from women, taking their share to approximately 82%. In the previous three elections (2011, 2016, and 2021), women had more or less shared the honours with men for the increase in voter turnout. The share in 2011 was a little less than 60%, whereas

it was about 50% on the two other occasions. Even though the share of women in additional voters this time has created an all-time high record, the tally of 20.8 lakh more women voters comes third in terms of absolute number, the highest being around 34.4 lakh in 2016 and 22.3 lakh in 2011. Five years ago, approximately 13.6 lakh more women turned up at the polling booths vis a vis 2016. The strong showing of women can be interpreted this way too: men did not show as much interest in the participation of the polling process as women did. In other words, if the women had not displayed the amount of interest they did, the total tally of extra voters would not have touched the current figure. A number of reasons could be adduced for greater interest of the women. Every major political party has promised schemes that can attract women voters. For all the hype generated by the political players in wooing more women, the growth rate of women voters this time over the previous poll was subdued. For instance, the number of women who voted this time was about 2.53 crore against 2.32 crore from last time, registering an almost 9% rise.

Electoral debuts in the State's Assembly elections tell a mixed story

N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

In Tamil Nadu's political theatre, the arrival of a new political party in the electoral contest has served as both a launchpad for historic realignments as well as a graveyard for grand ambitions. With the high profile debut of actor-politician C. Joseph Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) in the 2026 Assembly elections, expectations are high about whether his party could breach the Dravidian duopoly or merely dent its margins. A cursory look at the history of electoral debuts of select political parties in Assembly elections held in the past in the State offers both a roadmap and a warning. For this analysis only the general elections to the Assembly was taken into consideration and not

the byelection or Lok Sabha polls. One of the most consequential debut in Tamil Nadu's political history was that of the DMK in the 1957 Madras Legislative Assembly election. Formed in 1949 by C.N. Annadurai, the party had built considerable connect with the people through the Dravidian movement's literary and theatrical energy and as an alternative to the Congress. Though it skipped the first post Independence election, its leaders chose to enter the electoral arena in 1957. The DMK fielded nominees in 112 of the 167 Assembly constituencies. All of them contested as independents and won 15 seats. The prominent leaders elected included Annadurai, M. Karunanidhi, K. Anbazhagan, and Sathiyavani Muthu. The party's nominees

polled 16.53 lakh votes, with a vote share of around 14.8%. Prominent losers included V.R. Nedunchezhiyan, Kannadasan, and S.S. Rajendran. By 1962, its first election under its own symbol, the DMK had won 50 of 143 seats it contested with 27.1%, before sweeping to power in 1967. A decade later, the political landscape had transformed. In 1972, the DMK's strongman and matinee idol M.G. Ramachandran was expelled from the party and he floated the ADMK, later rechristened the AIADMK. The 1977 Assembly election, held after the Emergency, was a four cornered contest among the DMK, AIADMK, Congress, and the Janata Party. The debutant AIADMK contested 200 seats and won 130. MGR became Chief Minister and the party polled an impressive



C. Joseph Vijay

30.36%. The Pattali Makkal Katchi, founded by S. Ramadoss in 1989 out of agitations demanding exclusive reservation, particularly for Vanniyars, transformed the Vanniyar Sangam into a political vehicle. In its 1991 Assembly debut, the party contested 194 seats but won only one seat. Panruti S. Ramachandran, a former DMK and later AIADMK Minister, won the Panruti constituency. Despite a massive sympathy wave for the

Congress-AIADMK alliance following the assassination of former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in Sriperumbudur, the PMK polled a creditable 5.89% vote share. The 1996 election produced two simultaneous debuts, each with sharply contrasting fortunes. A split in the Congress party saw veteran leader G.K. Moopanar form the Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar) only a few months before polling. His party aligned with the DMK and backed by actor Rajinikanth amid a fierce anti-incumbency wave against the AIADMK government. The TMC(M) contested 40 seats and won 39, making an impressive debut with a 9.30% vote share. Known for his firebrand oratory, DMK Rajya Sabha Member Vaiko broke away from the party to form the

Marumalarchi Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam in 1994. The party made its debut in 1996, contesting 177 seats. Though it polled 5.78% of the votes, it failed to win any seats. Identifying himself as 'Black MGR' and popularly known as 'Captain' in cinema circles, Vijayakant founded the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam in 2005. He chose to go solo in the 2006 Assembly election by contesting in 232 constituencies, with Vijayakant emerging as its sole winner from Vriddachalam. The party polled 8.38%, earning recognition as a State party. With an ideologically distinct base rooted in Tamil nationalism and opposed to Dravidian parties, the Naam Tamilar Katchi, led by Seeman, made its electoral debut in 2016. It contested 231 consti-

cies but failed to win any seats, polling a 1.06% vote share. A breakaway faction of the AIADMK, the Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam led by T.T.V. Dhinakaran, made its Assembly election debut in 2021, although it had earlier entered electoral politics in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, with its candidates contesting as independents. In 2021, the AMMK contested 165 seats and polled 2.35%. Positioning itself as an alternative to the Dravidian majors, the Makkal Needhi Maam, led by actor-politician Kamal Haasan, also made its Assembly election debut in 2021 and contested 180 seats. The party polled 2.62% vote share. However, it failed to win any seats. Like the AMMK, the MNM had earlier made its electoral debut in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls.

DMK asks EC to ensure peaceful counting of votes in State

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The DMK on Sunday urged the Election Commission of India (EC) to ensure peace, public order, and the integrity of the vote-counting process across Tamil Nadu on May 4. In a letter to Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik, DMK organisation secretary R.S. Bharathi said the party had received "credible information" about the alleged plans of the BJP and others to disrupt the counting of votes. He warned that such disruptions could extend to areas around the counting booths and other sensitive locations, raising concerns about possible large-scale law and order issues that might affect free and fair election.

The DMK urged the EC to take immediate steps, including the deployment of adequate security personnel and close coordination with law enforcement agencies. A copy of the letter was also sent to the Director-General of Police. In another development on Sunday, the AIADMK petitioned election officials to prevent any unauthorised entry into counting centres. There are 62 counting centres all over Tamil Nadu. In a representation to the Chief Election Commissioner, the Chief Electoral Officer, and the Special Observer, AIADMK functionary and Rajya Sabha Member I.S. Inbadurai flagged the alleged "misuse of press passes to gain unauthorised entry into the counting centres". Such a scenario might "seriously affect the fairness and transparency of the counting process", he said, citing reports that individuals associated with the DMK IT Wing had requested the district authorities for press passes.

Govt. school teacher held under POCSO Act after student ends life in Mayiladuthurai district

The Hindu Bureau
MAYILADUTHURAI

The Manalmedu police on Sunday arrested a 42-year-old teacher at a government school on charges of sexually harassing a Class X student and abetting her suicide. The accused has been booked under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. The victim, a 16-year-old girl from a village within the Manalmedu police limits, recently appeared for her Class X board examinations. On April 27, the girl tried to end her life and was rushed to the Thanjavur Government Medical College and Hospital, where she died on April 28. The girl's mother filed a complaint with the Manalmedu police, naming Karthikeyan, an English teach-

er at the school where her daughter studied, as being responsible for her death. The complainant alleged that Karthikeyan, a resident of Manakunnam in Thanjavur district, had been frequently calling and messaging the girl, causing her significant mental distress. The woman said she had warned the teacher to stop contacting her daughter. Road blockade Initially, the police registered a case of suspicious death under Section 194 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS). However, local residents and the victim's relatives staged a road blockade, demanding a thorough investigation and claiming that the teacher's sexual harassment was the direct cause

of the extreme step taken by the minor. "During the investigation, it was confirmed through phone records that the teacher had been sending inappropriate messages and making frequent calls to the student, amounting to sexual harassment," a senior police officer said. Following the investigation, the police altered the case to include charges of abetment of suicide and sections of the POCSO Act. Karthikeyan, who is married and has two children, was arrested and produced before a local court, which remanded him in judicial custody. (Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State's health helpline 104 and Snea's suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050)

TNEA 2026 counselling process kicks off with release of tentative schedule

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Directorate of Technical Education (DoTE) has released the tentative schedule for Tamil Nadu Engineering Admissions (TNEA) 2026, kicking off the process of admission from Sunday. The online portals for registration of students have been thrown open. The last date for registration of online application is June 2 and the last date for uploading documents is June 6. Students may log on to www.tneonline.org and www.dte.tn.gov.in for registration. The fee for the registration process is ₹250 for students of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes and ₹500 for the rest. During the online registration, the students should upload their certificates for verification. In case of discrepancies, the



Awaiting nod: Counselling dates will be announced after approval from the AICTE, say TNEA officials. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

student would be contacted on their registered mobile number and email ID and may have to report to a TNEA Facilitation Centre (TFC) at a notified time. The certificate verification process will be held between June 8 and June 20 and the rank list will be released on June 29. Students will get a chance to redress their grievances pertaining to the TNEA

process between June 30 and July 4. According to TNEA officials, the counselling dates will be announced after approval from the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE). Students who require assistance for the registration process may walk into any of the 110 TFCs set up across the State. The addresses and phone num-

bers of the TFCs are available on the TNEA website. Students may call the integrated call centre set up at the DoTE on the toll free number 1800 425 0110 between 8 a.m. and 6 p.m. or email tneacare@gmail.com for clarifications about the online registration process. On the website, the candidates will find detailed instructions in Tamil and English, the tentative schedule, the process for uploading certificates, cut-off marks for the previous five years of TNEA, details of TFCs, and sample certificates for admission under the special quota, the TNEA said in a press release. In 2025, the number of colleges that took part in the counselling process was 443, offering 2,54,585 seats. The number of students enrolled was 2,20,841, a 23.67% increase from the 2024 figures, the release added.

High cost of five kg FTL cylinders keeps new consumers away

Consumers say a new five kg FTL connection costs ₹1,760, which is very high, and the cylinder will not last for 41 days unlike the regular cylinder

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

With liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) distributors only providing five kg cylinders to those opting for new connections, not many are opting for it due to its high cost. A fresh five kg free trade LPG (FTL) connection costs around ₹1,760 including the cost of a cylinder. At the same time, a domestic 14.2 kg cylinder costs around ₹930. Distributors say that they are only following instructions from State-run oil marketing companies (OMCs) and are providing these five kg FTL cylinders to migrant labourers, those coming on transfers, and newly-weds. “It is a stop gap arrangement till the situation improves. We stopped all new connections a month back,” said a distributor.

D. Rani, who shares her double bottle connection with her daughter-in-law, said both her bottles were empty and when she asked the agency for a new connection, they said it would not be possible. “I cannot afford the five kg cylinder. It is expensive and won’t last 41 days like the regular cylinder. As it is, the rate of the 14.2 kg cylinder has gone up since last month,” she said. Getting new com-



Severe restriction: Distributors limit new connections to migrant labourers, those coming on transfers, and newly-weds.

mercial connections too is not easy now. “We are giving commercial connections only to those whose requirements are small. These are people who were dependent on private companies earlier. If the case is genuine, we provide connections telling them to use the gas wisely,” said another distributor. In such a situation, those running PGs and hostels are having a tough time managing food for their guests. R. Venkatasubbaiah, secretary, Tamil Nadu IT Hostel and PG Owners Welfare Association, said that there were around 12,000 such facilities in and around the city that had registered with their association. “We cannot cook using wood inside the city

due to space constraints. Before the war, we used to take gas cylinders from various agencies. But now, we are forced to obtain cylinders in the black market. Last month, when a cylinder was sold at ₹7,000, many hesitated. Now, the rate in the black market has come down to ₹6,000 a cylinder. We hope we can get connections so that we need not depend on the black marketers,” he said. Distributors say that their supply of 14.2 kg domestic cylinders has been restricted based on their backlog. “We are being told to ensure that consumers take only one cylinder per month and not more.” Over 70 agencies have backlogs of over 10 days.



(From left) Amar Agarwal, Chairman, Agarwals Eye Hospital; C. Sridhar, Vice-Chancellor of the Meenakshi Academy of Higher Education and Research; and Ashvin Agarwal, Chief Clinical Officer, Agarwals Eye Hospital on Sunday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Meet discusses latest advances in treating in retinal disorder

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Ophthalmology experts from across the country gathered here on Sunday for a conference organised by Dr. Agarwals Group, where discussions centred on recent advances in retinal care.

The one-day event focused on developments in the diagnosis and management of vitreoretinal disorders, highlighting emerging techniques and technologies in the field. The conference was inaugurated by C. Sridhar, Vice-Chancellor of the Meenakshi Academy of Higher Education and Research, in the presence of Amar Agarwal, Chairman; Ashvin Agarwal, Chief Clinical Officer; and Manoj Khatri, Director, Vitreo-Retinal Services, Dr. Agarwals Eye Hospital. Around 50 speakers led sessions on medical and surgical retina, covering emerging techniques, retinal vascular disease management, and advances in clinical practice. Wet lab

sessions were also part of the programme. Dr. Khatri outlined a technique developed by the group – pinhole pupiloplasty (PPP) – in which a small, focused opening is created in the pupil to allow only concentrated light to enter, thereby reducing distortion and improving visual clarity. He said the position of the pinhole could be adjusted to bypass damaged areas of the eye. Based on the principle of the pinhole test used in eye examinations, the procedure has improved visual acuity in selected cases and may help avoid corneal transplants in 20%-30% of the patients. Dr. Amar Agarwal said PPP could benefit patients who are unable to access corneal donors or face long waiting periods, as it is a day care procedure that can restore vision as early as the next day. He added that India bears one of the highest burdens of diabetes, and urged patients to undergo regular eye check-ups.

Three counting centres inspected

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Ahead of vote counting on Monday, the Chennai District Election Office inspected the preparedness at three counting centres in the district. Electronic voting machines (EVM) were kept under three-tier security at Queen Mary’s College, Loyola College, and Anna

University after polling on April 23. Counting observers have been appointed for each constituency to supervise the process. Counting halls for Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar, Thiru.Vi.Ka Nagar, Royapuram, Harbour and Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni Assembly constituencies have been set up at Queen Mary’s College. Loyola College has been designated

as the counting centre for six constituencies – Perambur, Kolathur, Villivakkam, Egmore, Thousand Lights and Anna Nagar. Counting halls for five constituencies – Virugambakkam, Saidapet, Thiyagarayanagar, Mylapore and Velachery – have been set up at Anna University. Postal ballots and service voter ballots will be counted at separate tables.

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REFERRED TO: Schedule A
All that parcel of land Plot No. 2-B-1 being part of 25 rounds and 500 sq.ft., comprised in S. No. 169/1 and 169/2 (Part) in Palmsah No. 960 and situate in No. 140, Thiruvanniyur Village in the Registration District of South-Madras and Registration Sub-District of Saidapet Total Extent: 1232 sq.ft.

Schedule B
All that parcel of land Plot No. 2-B-2 being part of 25 grounds and 500 sq.ft., comprised in S. No. 169/1 and 169/2 (Part) in Palmsah No. 960 and situate in No. 140, Thiruvanniyur Village in the Registration District of South-Madras and Registration Sub-District of Saidapet Total Extent: 1300 sq.ft.

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More than 700 guests attended a three-day Sri Lanka Food Festival 2026 held at Green Meadows Resort in Chennai recently. An expert culinary team led by distinguished chefs from Cinnamon Grand Hotel, Colombo, participated. The festival was organised by the Deputy High Commissioner of Sri Lanka, Ganesanathan Geathiswaran. It provided a unique platform to showcase the diverse culinary heritage of Sri Lanka. The primary objective was to strengthen the cultural ties between Sri Lanka and South India, while promoting tourism and trade, a release said.

The Dementia Care Foundation will organise a free summer camp from May 11 to 15, between 9.30 a.m. and 1 p.m., at CURi Hospital in Thoraipakkam. It aims to foster meaningful inter-generational bonding through engaging activities. For further details, visit www.thedementiacarefoundation.com. To register, call 7397474888/+91 9344257901.

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

In a first, NH stretch given red markings to enhance visibility

About 34% of the four-lane corridor running from Thoppur Kanigarahalli in Dharmapuri district to Sakkarapatti in Salem district has been completed.

The summer showers also damaged crops.

Interactive workshops make archaeology more accessible to students, says expert

“When we studied, we did not have anything separately for archaeology in the textbook; it was all part of history. School textbooks nowadays include information on Keeladi and other sites, but it is still limited. That is why, through workshops and field visits, students are able to get hands-on experience,” he says.

VCK, Left plan protest against LPG price hike

THE HINDU
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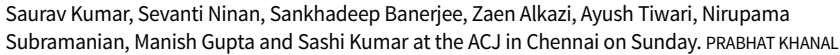
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The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

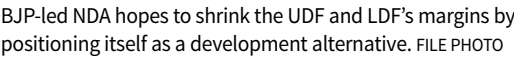
N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group, observed that journalism is unfolding in an era defined by a deep information paradox, where, despite an explosion of available information, citizens in many democracies are less informed about public affairs. The distinction, he noted, lies in the fact that

The ACJ Awards for Journalism were presented. Ayush Tewari won the 2025 ACJ Award for Investigative Journalism for his series on India's cyberscam industry, published in *Scroll*.

In the social impact category, Aparna Ganesan received a Special Mention for her video report on the hidden costs of solar energy in *The Migration Story*, while Safeena Wani was recognised for her report on the impact of renewable energy projects on Ladakh's pashmina ecosystem in *Down To Earth*.

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

that it stood a fighting chance to win back voters,

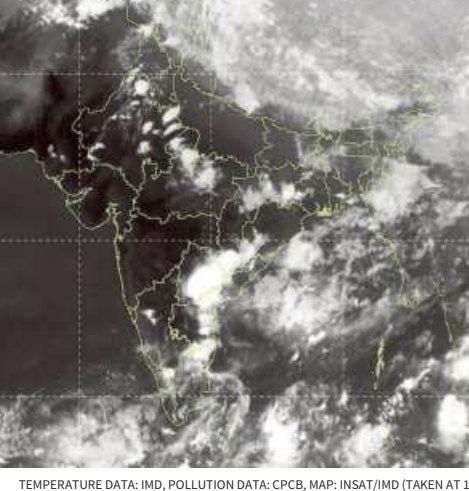


LDF leaders had signalled confidence that vo-

The BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) is hoping to shrink the UDF and LDF's margins by positioning itself as a Centre-backed development alternative. The BJP has primarily targeted "dissatisfied LDF and UDF" voters, and sees itself as best placed to benefit from the "unpopularity" of the traditional alliances.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: PCB, MAP-INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu. Thunderstorm accompanied with hailstorm very likely at isolated places over Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Haryana, and Uttar Pradesh. Dust storm very likely at isolated places over Rajasthan, hot and humid weather very likely at isolated places over coastal Andhra Pradesh.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		29.8	20.7	Kozhikode		37.6	27.9
Ahmedabad		42.0	28.0	Kurnool		43.1	29.3
Aizawl	13.0.....	28.2	17.5	Lucknow	7.0.....	33.3	21.4
Allahabad		36.0	25.6	Madurai	47.0.....	34.0	21.1
Bengaluru		35.4	23.4	Mangaluru		33.7	25.5
Bhopal	2.0.....	40.4	22.4	Mumbai		34.4	28.0
Bhubaneswar	5.6.....	30.2	23.0	Mysuru		35.6	19.6
Chandigarh	19.7.....	33.2	17.1	New Delhi		35.1	23.4
Chennai		37.8	29.6	Patna		29.4	23.6
Coimbatore		36.4	24.0	Port Blair		29.4	23.6
Dehradun	1.9.....	32.4	19.4	Puducherry		38.8	27.0
Gangtok	12.0.....	19.3	13.0	Pune		40.0	24.0
Goa		35.2	26.6	Raipur		41.5	
Guwahati	4.0.....	28.8	20.9	Ranchi	11.0.....	33.6	20.0
Hubbballi		38.0	21.0	Shillong			
Hyderabad		40.0	22.4	Shimla	5.0.....	19.6	14.0
Imphal	3.5.....	25.3	16.3	Srinagar	3.0.....	23.2	11.6
Jaipur	5.0.....	38.3	22.0	Thiruvananthapuram		36.2	26.6
Kochi		33.0	26.4	Tiruchi	9.0.....	37.7	22.6
Kohima		20.0	14.0	Vijayawada			
Kolkata	11.0.....	32.6	22.4	Visakhapatnam		32.4	28.8

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE
Ahmedabad	42	33		60	124	Orange
Bengaluru	4		41	140	145	Orange
Chennai	4		40	98	63	Orange
Delhi	12	51	77	114	240	Red
Hyderabad	19	16	21	57	97	Green
Kolkata	10	14	50	26	47	Green
Lucknow	8	40	34	61	110	Orange
Mumbai	17	14	30	33	102	Orange
Pune		22	102	33	62	Orange
Visakhapatnam	26	56	27	31	110	Orange

Yesterday

In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Panipat, Haryana recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 298 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Chikkamagaluru, Karnataka recorded a healthy AQI score of 21

Air Quality Code:

■ Poor
 ■ Moderate
 ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

NO: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

SO: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

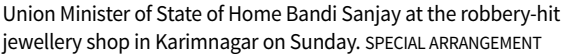
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Tough work: A woman carrying firewood for use as domestic fuel at Tarluvada village near Visakhapatnam on Sunday. Summer is when rural communities stock up on firewood for the rainy and winter seasons. V. RAJU

The Hindu Bureau
KARIMNAGAR

It is suspected that an inter-State gang of robbers executed the daring crime in the heart of the town after studying the area.



The three injured staffers were shifted to a nearby hospital and their condition was said to be stable. The exact value of the sto-

The footage obtained from a CCTV camera at the entrance of the jewellery showed the five assailants running towards the main road with one of them carrying a large bag. The Karimnagar police have an-

Union Minister of State for Home Bandi Sanjay, who visited the shop on Sunday afternoon, commended the jewellery staff's bravery after they were injured resisting the robbery. He said the miscreants who entered the shop under the guise of customers opened fire on the sales manager and other staff when the latter tried to foil their robbery attempt. The police will ascertain the exact quantity of the stolen jewellery during the investigation, he said, exuding confidence that they will apprehend the robbers soon.

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

These works pertain to small, scattered stretches, ranging between 50 metres and 60 metres, which were left incomplete due to various constraints by the original executing agencies during 2015-16, resulting in discontinuities along the canal. An estimated ₹48 crore to ₹56

The completion of these gaps was a crucial step in strengthening the canal infrastructure ahead of commissioning the Polavaram project in 2027. The RMC was designed to handle discharge capacity of 17,500 cusecs, much higher than the current capacity of 6,000 cusecs. Officials were optimistic that the canal would meet future irrigation demands.

The Hindu Bureau
SHIVAMOGGA

Following this, the Returning Officer of Sringeri declared Mr. Jeevaraj of the BJP as being duly elected to the State Assembly from the constituency. With this, Mr. Jeevaraj has now



It may be noted that Mr.



The Returning Officer told presspersons after the

Responding to Sunday's developments, Deputy Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said that they would take the fight to court.

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Mr. Prasanth was placed on suspension on November 11, 2024, for levelling serious allegations against A. Jayathilak, then Addi-

Both Mr. Ashok and Mr. Prasanth have appeared together on YouTube videos and on public forums, levelling allegations against the LDF leadership.

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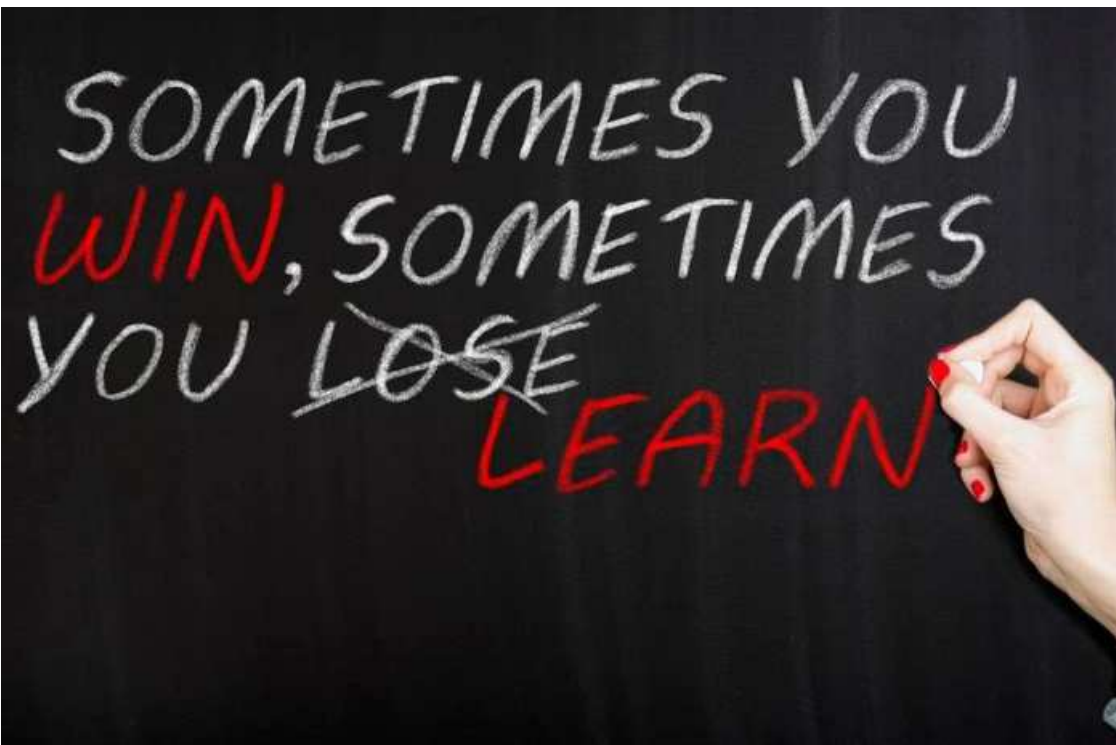
May is here and the Board exam results are out. Your phone is buzzing with calls from relatives and your parents are fielding calls from people you barely remember. Everyone wants to know how you did. Before you answer that, can we pause for a moment? Not to avoid the question, but to ask a better one: what is a result, really?

Think of it like a milestone on a highway. It tells you where you are right now, not where you are going; definitely not who you are. When you see a board that says 500 km to Chennai, it is just a marker. It does not tell you if Chennai is even where you want to go. What matters is what you do when you reach it.

Clues to yourself

If you did well in the exam, enjoy it. But do not stop there. Did you find your own way of understanding things? Did you stay consistent when it got tiring? Was there a subject you genuinely enjoyed? These are clues, not just about exams, but about you.

Each of us has what I like to call a power zone. It is that space where the way your mind naturally works meets something the world actually needs. Some people make complicated things simple without trying. Some carry 10 moving parts in their



go through life without asking what they are good at. It is easier to compare marks, colleges, placements. But that is someone else's measure, not yours. What comes naturally to you? What do you enjoy? What makes you lose track of time? If you do not know yet, it is okay. Look at where the world is heading, then look at what you are drawn to. Where those two meet is a good place to begin. You do not need perfect clarity. You just need direction.

A word to parents. Your child's result is not your report card. When we make it about our own image, we add to the pressure they are already carrying. What they need is someone who can stay calm and say "this is one moment. I see you beyond this."

You know your score. Ask yourself what it is telling you and what it is not. The people who go on to do meaningful things are not always the ones with the highest marks. They are the ones who learned to understand themselves and keep moving forward, through both success and failure.

That confidence does not come from marks. It builds when you choose honesty over excuses and curiosity over comparison. May is a good month to begin.

The writer is Junior Faculty - Organisation Behaviour and Human Resource at Great Lakes Institute of Management, Chennai.

Beyond the marksheet

As board exam results season begins, an educator reflects on what marks mean and how to deal with success and failure

head without dropping any. Some are the person everyone calls when a conflict needs sorting. These are not soft skills but the engines that run careers and lives.

However, if you did not do well, stay with me. An exam you did not clear is not a wall. It is a question: what happened here? Not "am I a failure?" Because that is a story you are telling

yourself. Instead, ask "What did this exam expect from me? Where did I fall short?" Was it time-management? A gap in understanding? Anxiety taking over? Each has a different answer.

Own both
Panic will not help you find it, but an honest question will. Own both the win and the miss. If

you did well, do not brush it aside saying you were lucky. A win you do not accept does not teach you anything. If you did not do well, own that too. Not to be hard on yourself but to stay in control of what comes next. The moment you start blaming the paper or the situation, you give away your ability to change things. The gap it shows will

stay until you are willing to look at it.

If success goes to your head, it makes you careless. If failure goes to your heart, it makes you shrink. What you need is for both to reach your mind. However, be careful of quick fixes.

After the results are declared, there will be a lot of advice: do a course. Take a certification. Try something else. Some of this may genuinely help. But, sometimes, it is just a way to avoid a difficult question. If you move on without understanding why you struggled, the same pattern will repeat itself. The real question is not just "what next?" but "what am I building towards?"

Here is something we do not talk about enough. Many people

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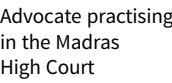


By opening up the so-called Sahyog portal to police officials around the country, requests under Section 79(3)(b) have been supercharged as a censorial rubber stamp that the IT Act simply does not give them. The clear Supreme Court precedent outlining what “actual knowledge” of illegality online constitutes for takedown orders has been reduced to a mockery. The Karnataka High Court has even brushed aside binding Court precedent under *Shreya Singhal vs Union of India*, even as the government has not dared to formalise the powers that it is exercising by passing a law in Parliament. Social media platforms have failed miserably in acting as a check in this ongoing rampage for power over online speech and have instead chosen the peace of mind that comes with automatically processing takedown notices. X continues to resist the Sahyog portal, but faces pressure from proceedings in the Karnataka and Delhi High Courts. The political elite must ponder the consequences of its campaign against online speech. Opposition-ruled States have quickly leapt to leverage the Sahyog portal’s powers. A future government run by today’s Opposition will likely play by the same sordid rules.

Decisions to go for abortion must be guided by sound medical advice

The entire argument hinges on gestational age, which, as an indicator of how far along the pregnancy is, is crucial to deciding whether an abortion would be safe. Most countries that have legalised abortion restrict the period of safe abortion to 24 weeks of gestation, primarily because of the negative implications for the life and health of the mother, after that. But, central to legal abortion is a medical assessment of risks. Will a child or her parents alone, with lay knowledge, be able to make a studied assessment of such risk? While the minor expresses her desire to be rid of a forced pregnancy, it is the role of her parents and the system to provide her with safe options, within the permissible period. Making an uninformed decision at this stage could be counterproductive, if it compromises on her health or life, while allowing the right to bodily autonomy.

“But the magnitude of the changes we expect and the potential risks we foresee demand even more,” it says. “We are entering a new phase of economic and social organization that will fundamentally reshape work, knowledge, and production. It requires not just incremental policy responses but ambitious policy ideas for tomorrow.”



Beyond issues of surveillance, privacy and

The problem is that most of us have not so much as started asking ourselves what a just future with AI would look like. Instead, we seem to have accepted that there is no alternative. In the process, we have all fallen into the Thatcherite trap.

Letters emailed to
letters@thehindu.co.in
must carry the postal address.

A countdown to International Day of Yoga

At a time when the world is navigating conflict, uncertainty, and rising psychological strain, the idea of peace demands renewed attention. Traditionally approached through diplomacy and policy, peace is often framed as an external goal, negotiated across borders and institutions. Yet, despite these efforts, societies remain increasingly unsettled, suggesting that peace cannot be secured externally alone. It must also be cultivated within. Yoga facilitates this journey.

The global community recognised this potential when the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) adopted a resolution in 2014, leading to the declaration of June 21 as the International Day of Yoga. The proposal itself was visionary, first articulated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi during his address to the 69th Session of the UNGA, where he described yoga as an invaluable gift of India's ancient tradition – one that embodies the unity of mind and body, thought and action. The first observance in 2015, under the theme “Yoga for Harmony and Peace,” reflected a shared aspiration to build more balanced and cohesive societies. This vision was further reinforced in 2018 with the theme “Yoga for Peace,” underlining the role of Yoga as a unifying force in an increasingly fragmented world.

Importantly, this emphasis has not been confined to individual years. Across successive International Day of Yoga observances, the ideas of balance, interconnectedness, and collective well-being have remained central. These themes are not merely symbolic – they represent a sustained global effort to position yoga as a practice that connects individuals across cultures, geographies, and ideologies, reinforcing peace as a shared and participatory process.

This growing global recognition was further strengthened in 2016, when yoga was inscribed on UNESCO's Representative List of



Prataprao Jadhav

Union Minister of State (IC) for Ayush and Minister of State for Health and Family Welfare

By encouraging mindfulness and emotional regulation, Yoga equips individuals with the ability to manage stress and respond thoughtfully

the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. While deeply rooted in India's civilisational ethos, Yoga today belongs to the world. Its universality lies in its simplicity – it requires no elaborate infrastructure, no exclusive access, and transcends cultural boundaries.

It is in this spirit that the Morarji Desai National Institute of Yoga, Ministry of Ayush, Government of India organised the ‘Yoga Mahotsav 2026’ on May 2, at the Kanha Shanti Vanam.

Bridging the gap

Yoga offers a way to bridge the gap between inner imbalance and external discord by strengthening the individual's capacity for awareness, balance, and restraint. Rooted in India's traditional knowledge systems, Yoga is not merely a physical routine but a discipline that harmonises the body, mind, and breath.

Through this integration, it enables individuals to respond to situations with clarity rather than impulse.

This distinction is critical. Much of the conflict witnessed today, whether in personal interactions or public discourse, does not arise solely from deep divisions but from the inability to regulate response. Yoga, through practices such as breath control and meditation, develops precisely this capacity. It creates space between stimulus and reaction – where reflection replaces reaction, and understanding tempers instinct. It is through this shift in individual behaviour that Yoga begins to shape peace at a broader, societal level. In a world reacting faster than it reflects, Yoga restores the discipline of pause.

In this context, Yoga has also emerged as one of India's most significant instruments of soft power. Unlike conventional forms of influence that rely on assertion, yoga operates through participation and shared experience. It creates moments of collective stillness in an otherwise fragmented world, fostering trust,

mutual respect, and a sense of global unity – values that are essential for lasting peace.

The relevance of Yoga becomes even more pronounced in the present global landscape. Rapid urbanisation, digital overstimulation, and shifting social dynamics have contributed to rising stress levels, shrinking attention spans, and increasingly reactive forms of communication. In such conditions, the absence of inner equilibrium often translates into external friction. Yoga addresses this challenge at its root. By encouraging mindfulness and emotional regulation, it equips individuals with the ability to manage stress and respond thoughtfully. When adopted widely, this shift in behaviour has the potential to influence collective outcomes, strengthening social cohesion and fostering more resilient communities.

The Ministry of Ayush has been committed to advancing this vision by integrating Yoga into public health, education, and community initiatives. The objective is not periodic participation, but sustained behavioural transformation that supports both individual well-being and societal harmony. Events like the ‘Yoga Mahotsav 2026’ are not merely commemorative – they are catalytic, bringing people together in a shared experience of awareness, balance, and collective intent. Peace, ultimately, is not a singular milestone but a continuous process, shaped by how individuals think, act, and engage with one another. Yoga, in its depth and universality, offers a practical means to nurture this process.

As the world moves toward the International Day of Yoga 2026, the message is both simple and profound: lasting peace will not be negotiated only across tables, but also cultivated within individuals. Yoga, in this sense, is not merely a practice – it is a quiet, enduring architecture of peace.

Naidu's industrial push for Andhra

The Chief Minister's ambitious drive for investments has given rise to concerns

STATE OF PLAY

Sumit Bhattacharjee

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In 1995, when Nara Chandrababu Naidu became the Chief Minister of Andhra Pradesh (then undivided), he began pitching Hyderabad as the new IT destination of the country. He was able to make due on that claim, when in 1998, IT giant Microsoft established a global R&D centre in the city. This proved to be a game changer for both Mr. Naidu and the State as soon Hyderabad came to be regarded as a major IT destination for global firms, with other majors such as Oracle, Google, Amazon, and Cognizant making a beeline for Hyderabad.

Ever since then, Mr. Naidu has basked in the success of transforming Hyderabad, with the achievement featuring prominently in all his subsequent political campaigns.

After a setback in 2004, Mr. Naidu returned to power in 2014 as part of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), following the bifurcation of the State, and once again focussed on IT; only this time, he pitched Visakhapatnam as the IT destination of the residuary Andhra Pradesh. Apart from IT, Mr. Naidu also proposed developing a greenfield capital at Amaravati.

However, his 2014-19 tenure was riddled with controversies, and his formidable Opposition – the YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) led by a much younger Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy – picked holes in several of the initiatives he had undertaken. Towards the end of his term, he bitterly parted ways with the NDA. Mr. Reddy capitalised on this vulnerability and won the 2019 elections with a thumping majority.



But Mr. Naidu is not one to be written off easily. He highlighted the shortcomings of his opponents; mended ties with the NDA leadership; brought Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party into the alliance; and reduced the YSRCP from 151 seats to just 11 seats in 2024. He is now back at the helm of affairs and appears to be leading an industrial push in the State.

A new vision

Mr. Naidu has now succeeded in roping in Google to set up its first 1 GW (gigawatt) hyper-scale AI data centre outside the U.S., in the Tarluvada village near Visakhapatnam, with an investment plan of about \$15 billion.

While there are several concerns surrounding the project – including issues related to water, power, land holdings and the environment – Mr. Naidu has stated that these will be addressed with both the State government and Google working to resolve them. There is a strong view within the tech community that although Google may not directly employ a large number of people, it could act as an anchor, attracting companies in IT, AI, finance and banking. This could mirror the catalytic role Microsoft played in Hyderabad.

Unlike the 1990s, when Mr. Naidu primarily focussed on an IT-driven growth model, this time he is also emphasising on core sectors. He has en-

couraged stakeholders to leverage regional strengths and optimise resource utilisation across districts. Leveraging Visakhapatnam's coastline, port infrastructure and iron ore supply, ArcelorMittal Nippon Steel India has grounded a 17.8 MTPA steel plant at Rajayyapeta in Anakapalli. Mr. Naidu has also pitched for investments from MNCs such as LG and Carrier in Sri City in the Tirupati region, along with several other big-ticket proposals, including an \$82,000 crore green energy project from Re-New. He has also identified zones for a drone city, defence hub and space city in the Rayalaseema region. At present, Mr. Naidu's image as a ‘CEO-style’ administrator seems to be attracting investments.

However, the question of continuity looms large. In 2019, when Mr. Naidu lost power, several projects were stalled and tenders were reversed. This cycle of policy reversals has had an adverse impact on the State. Therefore, ensuring continuity of these projects, irrespective of which party is in power, will augur well for Andhra Pradesh.

Another key challenge for Mr. Naidu is to effectively capitalise on these big-ticket investments. Following Google, Reliance Industries is also in talks with the State to set up a 1.5 GW data centre. But the question is whether the government will be able to attract MNCs to set up shop by leveraging the advantage of high-speed data transfer through the sub-sea cables that will land in Visakhapatnam.

Also, fostering subsidiary industries to boost local employment while ensuring that environmental safeguards are not compromised will be equally important.

Electoral participation has been on a steady rise in India

Voter turnouts have been increasing over decades across States, and is not a sudden phenomenon

DATA POINT

Sanjay Kumar
Arindam Kabir

India's electoral participation has been rising across States, with the pattern being much broader than the recent trends in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, and Assam. Data shows that, over the past decade or so, voter turnout has increased in most States, with only a few exceptions, suggesting a sustained deepening of electoral engagement rather than a sudden increase.

The clearest takeaway from the data is that higher participation is not confined to one region or one political context. In Gujarat, voter turnout rose from 59.77% in 2007 to 64.84% in 2022, while in Uttar Pradesh, it moved from 45.96% to 61.08% in the same period. Goa saw a jump from 70.51% to 81.89%, and Manipur's voter turnout increased from 86.73% to 90.28% (Table 1). These are very different States in terms of geography, party competition, social composition, and turnout history, yet they show the same broad direction – more people are voting.

Karnataka's turnout rose from 64.84% to 73.84%, Madhya Pradesh's increased from 69.63% to 77.74%, Rajasthan from 66.49% to 75.33%, and Chhattisgarh's from 70.66% to 76.75% (Table 2).

Exceptions to the rise

The overall pattern is upward, but it is not universal. Punjab fell from 76.04% in 2007 to 72.15% in 2022, while Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, and Tripura show decline or near-stability over time. Haryana is another important exception, moving from 72.37% in 2009 to 67.89% in 2024 (Table 3). These cases matter because they show that turnout growth is not automatic and can be shaped by local political conditions, competition, and administrative factors.

At the same time, several States

that had already registered high voter turnout continued to do the same. Arunachal Pradesh's voter turnout rose from 79.45% in 2009 to 86.89% in 2024 (Table 3). Puducherry moved from 86.19% in 2011 to 89.85% in 2026 (Table 5). Kerala, West Bengal and Tamil Nadu have also shown increases. Kerala's voter turnout increased from 75.26% to 78.27%, Tamil Nadu's increased from 78.29% to 85.15% and West Bengal's from 84.72% to 92.47% (Table 5). West Bengal deserves special attention because it shows that rising turnout can occur even in a politically intense, highly competitive State. The State has long had one of the highest participation levels in India, yet turnout still moved upward from 84.72% in 2011 to 92.47% in 2026.

This is important because Bengal is often treated as an exceptional case in debates about electoral mobilisation. However, the numbers suggest something broader – participation has not only expanded in low-turnout States, it has also deepened in places where voting was already strong. Bengal therefore reinforces the central argument that the recent rise in voter turnout is part of a wider and long-term trend, not a sudden or isolated development. Even in States that already had relatively high turnout, the increase is visible, which suggests that participation gains are not limited to low-turnout States alone.

The data across different election cycles suggests that voter turnout has been building over time. Andhra Pradesh increased its voter turnout from 72.72% in 2009 to 81.79% in 2024, Odisha increased it from 65.35% to 74.79%, and Jharkhand has gone from 57.03% to 67.66% (Table 3). Similarly, Bihar has also increased its voter turnout from 52.73% in 2010 to 67.67% in 2025 (Table 4). Taken together, these numbers indicate a steady broadening of electoral participation across India's electoral landscape, and not a sudden increase.

This is important because it

places the recent surge in voter turnout across a longer time frame. The rise in participation is best understood as a decade-long trend with uneven outcomes across States, rather than as a sudden event limited to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR).

Not much impact

The SIR may have further increased voter turnout by changing the denominator, which can push the voter turnout percentage upward even when the underlying number of voters changes only modestly. That means its effect should be seen as additive rather than foundational. The more fundamental story is that voter turnout was already moving upward in many States well before any such exercises. This distinction is important for interpreting the numbers correctly. If voter turnout rises because the eligible voter base is recalibrated, that may amplify the final percentage. But the broader picture shows that the direction of movement was already upward across many States, so the SIR most likely worked on top of an existing trend rather than initiating it.

The broad increase in voter turnout points to stronger political engagement and possibly more effective mobilisation by parties and institutions. It may also reflect changing voter attitudes, better awareness, or a greater sense that elections matter. Whatever the mix of causes, the evidence suggests that India's electoral participation has become more expansive across States.

At the same time, the exceptions remind us that participation is not uniform. Some States have shown a downward trend too, and these variations deserve attention instead of being flattened into a single national story. Still, the overall direction is clear – across India, voter turnout has generally gone up, and recent factors like the SIR may have added to a rise that was already underway.

Parsing participation

The data for the tables were sourced from the Election Commission of India



Electoral mandate: An election officer puts the indelible ink mark on the index finger of a women at a polling booth in the Dr.Radhakrishnan Nagar constituency on April 23, 2026. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Table 1: Voter turnout (%) in the Assembly elections of 2007 and 2022			
States	2007	2022	
Gujarat	59.77	64.84	
Punjab	76.04	72.15	
Uttar Pradesh	45.96	61.08	
Goa	70.51	81.89	
Manipur	86.73	90.28	

Table 2: Voter turnout (%) in the Assembly elections of 2008 and 2023			
States	2008	2023	
Karnataka	64.84	73.84	
Madhya Pradesh	69.63	77.74	
Rajasthan	66.49	75.33	
Chhattisgarh	70.66	76.75	
Meghalaya	89.39	86.72	
Mizoram	82.33	82.26	
Nagaland	87.16	88.1	
Tripura	92.49	89.83	

Table 3: Voter turnout (%) in the Assembly elections of 2009 and 2024			
States	2009	2024	
Andhra Pradesh	72.72	81.79	
Haryana	72.37	67.89	
Maharashtra	59.68	65.11	
Odisha	65.35	74.79	
Jharkhand	57.03	67.66	
Arunachal Pradesh	79.45	86.89	
Sikkim	83.37	83.43	

Table 4: Voter turnout (%) in the Assembly elections of 2010 and 2025			
State	2010	2025	
Bihar	52.73	67.67	

Table 5: Voter turnout (%) in the Assembly elections of 2011 and 2026			
State	2011	2026	
Assam	76.04	85.96	
Kerala	75.26	78.27	
Tamil Nadu	78.29	85.15	
West Bengal	84.72	92.47	
Puducherry	86.19	89.85	

Higher participation is not confined to one region or one political context. Recent factors like SIR may have added to a rise that was already underway



Note: Sanjay Kumar is a professor, psephologist and election analyst.
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Views expressed by the authors are their own independent views, it does not reflect the views of the institution

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO MAY 4, 1976

Big haul from pawnbrokers' banker

Madras, May 3: One hundred and sixty kilograms of gold ornaments ranging from a ring to a huge gold necklace stored in 48 boxes and valued at Rs. 65 lakhs – claimed to be one of the biggest hauls in the country – were seized by the Central Excise officers from the residence of a “pawnbrokers banker” last Monday. These boxes had been stored in a strong room in the premises at Govindappa Naicken Street, George Town. The officers also seized cash of Rs. 63,000. The banker had neither declared possession of this huge quantity of gold ornaments nor even his personal jewellery.

Disclosing this at a press conference to-day, Mr. L.J. Rao, Collector of Central Excise said each box contained 100 to 1,500 items of gold jewellery. These boxes belonged to various pawnbrokers who had re-pledged them with their ‘banker’ and received advance of monies. Two Inspectors Mr. P. R. Krishnan and Mr. K. Rangaraj spent over 10 days gathering intelligence and finally located the premises. Fifteen officers led by Mr. E. J. Coelho, Assistant Collector and Mr. N.V. Kumaraswamy, Superintendent, entered the premises on April 26 and started an inventory of all the ornaments.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MAY 4, 1926

Ootacamund horse show

Ootacamund, May 3: The Ootacamund horse show was brought to a successful conclusion this afternoon. The show was voted one of the finest held in India and attached large number of prominent visitors who are now at the station. Among these were, besides His Excellency the Governor and the Hon'ble Cicely Goschen, Sir C.P. Ranaswami Iyer, the Maharaja and Junior Maharani of Travancore, the Maharani of Cooch Behar, the Maharaja of Bobbili, the Nawab of Tander, General Ponsonby the Raja of Kollengode, Sirdar Kaniaraj Ors and Devarj URs of Mysore.

The Open Jumping Competition for horses and ponies aroused keen competition, the prize eventually going to the Maharani of Cooch Behar's “Roulette.” The prize for the best pony or horse in the show went to the Maharani of Coen Bihar “Broad Fort” and that of the best pony to Mrs. Hildebrand's “Theodora.”

He also countered the government's claim that the project is strategically crucial, citing a recent piece by former Navy chief Arun Prakash that security concerns for Andaman and Nicobar must be separated from developments under the Great Nicobar project. Mr. Ramesh accused the government of trying to "muzzle genuine debate" by hiding behind "security considerations". "These considerations must, at the very least, be discussed and debated in Parliamentary forum," he said.

Assam verdict: Congress hopes to stop BJP run

The BJP gradually came to power, mostly in alliance with regional players, in Arunachal Pradesh, Manipur, Meghalaya, Nagaland, and Tripura. Polls in ethnic conflict-hit Manipur are due in 2027, while Meghalaya, Nagaland, and Tripura vote in 2028.

'I am one of the six victims,' says Vinesh Phogat ahead of WFI event at Brij Bhushan's hometown

Kharge slams Sangh Parivar over press freedom curbs

"Journalists are being murdered in BJP-ruled States for doing their job," he alleged. "Raghvendra Bajpai in Uttar Pradesh, Mukesh Chandrakar in Chhattisgarh, Rajeev Pratap Singh in Uttarakhand, and Dharmendra Singh Chauhan in Haryana, each of them was reporting on corruption and issues of public interest. Today, they stand as grim reminders of the cost of speaking truth to power," he said.

L-G galvanises major rally against drug abuse in Srinagar

Nishant launches Sadbhav Yatra from Bihar's West Champaran

His political entry is being seen as an important move for the survival of the party. On Monday, Nishant Kumar will hold his first public meeting in Bettiah.

A CH-CHE

Dodge that mis-selling bullet

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

Awareness is safety. Let the buyer beware. Nowhere is this truer than when buying insurance.

By the time you realise you have been a victim of mis-selling you are looking at a closed door. You have a useless or sub-optimal product and you cannot exit without considerable loss. You may even be in hospital or have lost a loved one - and the policy you bought is useless. Is there no way out? There is and it will take your effort, time and yes financial loss.

The escape hatch

The first opportunity for you to wiggle out of a bad insurance decision is in the fortnight after you receive your policy document. That window - the free-look period - is provided to you by the regulator enabling you to return the policy and seek a refund.

Read through the policy documents, see whether it suits your requirements, see if the terms, benefits and premium payment schedules are what you were told and promised when you bought it.

If you are unhappy for any reason, you can cancel the policy and get a refund. Amazing as that sounds, not too many people use this safety net. They are not aware or they are not that vigilant and also avoid an unpleasant job. And then there is the biggie: the document is daunting and



For relief: A customer can also use IRDAI's Bima Bharosa portal. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

discouraging to read with its clauses and difficult language. No matter, each policy bond has to be accompanied by a customer information sheet. Please read that if you want to backtrack from the policy.

The process

How to do it? Write to the insurer about what you were told and what you got and why it is unsuitable for you. Ask for cancellation and refund. If there is misrepresentation, the insurer may offer to modify or cancel and refund most of the premium.

The customer care/grievances officer's contact information will be on your policy and he has to respond by a certain time frame and address your issue. Escalate it within the company until you get a response. If unsuccessful use the IRDAI's Integrated Consumer Grievances Portal, now called Bima Bharosa, and then further the Insurance Ombudsman, consumer courts and regular courts as well.

It is not what happened, but what you can establish as happened that will be your strength. Your alertness has to start at the time of buying. Please put all queries in writing and get all promises, terms and conditions and assurances in writing. Be alert about disclosures and undertakings you sign as they are binding. Make sure to fill and sign the proposal form yourself and keep a photocopy.

Prevention better than cure

The final truth is you are better off avoiding mis-selling than fixing it. This means commitment to invest time and effort during the purchase. Be clear about the purpose of buying a cover. Learn which policies suit your needs. Ask all difficult queries until you get clear answers (in writing!) Get a second opinion! Talk to experts and family before buying. In the next instalment of CoverNote, we will give a wish list of consumer, seller and regulator behaviour to avoid the mess.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history.)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



Reading the mind: Marshmallow Test aimed at showing self-control predicts better life outcomes such as higher academic success. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Marshmallow myths and the waiting child

Perhaps, one of the world's most famous psychology experiments was run on full stomachs. But what about the child who is starving without a morsel of food?

CANDY CRUMBLES

Vaishali R. Venkat

This week, I'm taking you not to stock exchanges, banks or mutual fund houses, but to a different corner of the earth: war-torn streets. Imagine a child crying near a place where her home once stood. The roof is gone. The walls are gone. Her parents are gone. Only she remains. Now, place a marshmallow in front of the child. Tell her that if she waits for 15 more minutes, she would get one more. Ask yourself: will she wait?

Walk into a crumbling classroom in Sudan. Meet a girl who hasn't seen her home for more than two years. Will she wait to grab the second marshmallow? Enter a ravaged shelter home in Syria, where millions of people still need humanitarian aid. You see a bony boy with torn clothes. Will he wait? Now, ask the same question to a refugee child at a camp in Jordan, in Lebanon, in Turkey, in Afghanistan or elsewhere on this earth where children wait not only for a morsel of food, but also for safety, security and a breath of peace.

Now walk into a school in Washington DC. The hallways smell of fresh paint. The heater hums in the classroom. Crayons lie scattered on the floor. Toys spill from shelves. You see a boy with a lunch box in his hands. Inside it, a sand-



There is a third category of children. In this, the child is neither the Gaza nor the Washington type. It is in the middle of us. Who is the child?

with, an apple, a chocolate bar, wafers and berries. Now, hold the marshmallow in front of him. It has now become the poorest thing of all that's inside his lunchbox. Will he wait? Not at all. He doesn't care a damn about your marshmallow.

Same marshmallow but two reactions. The children in war-ravaged areas grab it immediately. Not because they lack self-control. But because in their world, it is the only thing that is real. For them, the promises of tomorrow were shattered several times. They were genuinely starving and so grabbed the marshmallow. The boy with berries in lunchbox does not even care to look.

But there is a third category of children. In this, the child is neither the Gaza nor the Washington type. It is in the middle of us. Who is the child?

The Marshmallow Test

In the U.S., in the late 1960s, Stanford University Professor Walter Mischel set out to study one of the most fundamental questions of human behaviour: Can a child's ability to control impulses predict its future success? He placed a



From a classroom in Stanford, tumbled out an entire philosophy of wealth creation. Delay gratification. Control impulses.

marshmallow in front of almost 600 children aged 4-6. One simple offer: wait for 15 minutes to get two. His follow-up research into the same children showed those who waited grew up with better grades, careers and financial habits. From a classroom in Stanford, tumbled out an entire philosophy of wealth creation. Delay gratification. Control impulses. And over a period, every money guru found a financial sermon – Save. Wait. Resist.

‘Sermon’ cracked

Not everyone appreciated the sermon. In 2013, Psychology professor Celeste Kidd made a startling discovery. She found children's wait-times reflected not only self-control but also reasoned beliefs about whether waiting would ultimately pay off.

Children who lived with reliable parents viz. those who kept up promises, waited longer. Children from unstable, unpredictable environments grabbed the marshmallow immediately. Not because they lacked self-control. But because their world had taught them that waiting rarely pays off. Five years later in 2018, researchers

Tyler Watts, Greg Duncan and Haonan Quan ran the same test on a broader sample of children from diverse backgrounds. When they took into account family background, early cognitive ability and the environment at home, the advantage of waiting reduced significantly.

The child who waited wasn't more disciplined. She simply came from a more stable home with caring parents.

Recent study

And in 2024, a study published in Child Development followed 702 children from the age of four all the way to age 26. The conclusion was simple: Grabbing the marshmallow instantly or waiting for the second one made no reliable difference to how successful the children became in their adult life.

Three studies. One quiet verdict. It was never about self-control, but was about circumstances. The first child's circumstances forced it to grab. The marshmallow itself became irrelevant for the Washington types.

But the third child is eagerly waiting. Faithfully. Patiently. Believing every word of the sermon. Who is the child? To know the answer, and to understand what it means for your money and your future, you will have to wait for your second marshmallow.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

Gold, silver listless

PRECIOUSMETALS

B. Krishnakumar

Precious metals prices were confined to a narrow range in April, influenced more by the developments surrounding the Middle East geopolitical conflict. The ceasefire between Iran and the U.S. sparked positive sentiment towards gold but the yellow metal cooled off in the last couple of weeks.

Comex gold closed a tad lower at \$4,636 by April end, a fall of 1.35%. Echoing the price behaviour of gold, Comex silver, too, closed a bit lower in April, sliding 1.5% to \$74.23/ ounce.

The performance of the precious metals in the domestic market was a little better owing to the weakening of the rupee against the U.S. Dollar.

Marginal gain

MCX Gold rose 0.26% in April to settle at ₹1,51,225/10-gram. MCX Silver closed 0.75% lower to ₹2,44,638/kg.

Comex gold price stays stuck in the \$4,400-\$5,650 zone mentioned in the prior months. There are no signs yet of a breakout from this range. In the near term, the price has to rise above \$5,050 to suggest the possibility of a meaningful upside move thereafter.

Until then, expect volatile, range-bound price action within the \$4,400-4,950 zone. While the long-term trend for Comex gold remains positive, the price has to move above \$5,260 for any significant upside move.

Comex silver price too was range-bound and devoid of any meaningful trend. The short-term outlook for silver does not appear too positive. A cool off to \$65-\$66 appears likely. On the upside, there is resistance at \$81-\$83 zone. As long as the price stays below \$83, a drop to \$65-\$66 is most likely. The long-term uptrend in silver would resume only a breakout above \$85.

In the domestic market too, the price action in gold was listless with the price being confined to the ₹1,45,000-₹1,75,000 range.

Only a breakout from this range would trigger the next big directional move in gold. In the near-term, there is a possibility of a rise to ₹1,53,000-₹1,55,000, a price is likely to drift lower thereafter to ₹1,40,000-₹1,43,000.

A move above ₹1,58,000 would suggest the possibility of a spike to ₹1,65,000-₹1,68,000.

Mimicking the trend in the global markets, MCX silver too was range-bound in April.

The price is may be confined to ₹2,26,000-₹2,61,000 range in the near term. Expect a meaningful trend to emerge in the direction of the breakout once the price gets off this short-term trading range. Until the breakout happens, volatile back and forth action within this range is the most likely.

Conclusion

To summarise, precious metals are likely to stay range bound in the near term. The long-term trend however stays strong for gold and silver.

(The author is a Chennai based analyst / trader. The views and opinion featured in this column is based on the analysis of short-term price movement in gold and silver futures at COMEX & Multi Commodity Exchange of India. This is not meant to be a trading or investment advice.)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.25	6.35	7.25	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.90	7.00	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	8.00	4.75	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	7.77	7.00	7.50	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	7.80	6.00	6.75	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	8.10	7.25	7.25	7.90
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.45	7.25	7.20	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	7.50	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.45	6.25	6.45	6.45
Bandhan Bank	7.25	7.00	7.25	5.85
City Union Bank	7.00	6.50	6.50	6.25
CSB Bank	7.35	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.60	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.15	6.90	7.00	7.15
Federal Bank	6.75	6.25	6.75	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.25	6.50	7.25	7.15
Indusind Bank	7.00	6.75	6.90	6.65

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Public Sector Banks				
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.25	6.75	6.65	6.60
IDBI Bank	6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	6.75	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.80	6.50	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBM Bank India	7.85	7.10	7.10	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.80	6.25	6.20	5.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.25	6.80	6.70	6.70
YES Bank	7.00	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.45	6.10	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.20	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.50	6.20	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.60	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.10
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.75	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.60	6.25	6.20	6.00

Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Public Sector Banks			
State Bank of India	7.25-8.95	7.25-8.95	7.25-8.95
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50
Punjab National Bank	7.30-9.30	7.25-9.20	7.25-9.20
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70
Indian Overseas Bank	7.10 #	7.10 #	7.10 #
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Private Sector Banks			
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.70 #	7.70 #	7.70 #
ICICI Bank	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
South Indian Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Karur Vysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Karnataka Bank	7.31-11.69	7.31-11.69	7.31-11.69

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
Federal Bank	8.30 - 10.757.30 - 10.757.30 - 9.75		
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30
Bandhan Bank	8.41-13.38	8.41-13.38	8.41-13.38
RBL Bank	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
CSB Bank	8.30 #	8.30 #	8.30 #
HDFC Bank	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
LIC Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Tata Capital	8.00 #	8.00 #	8.00 #
PNB Housing Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
GIC Housing Finance	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
SMFG India Home Finance	10.00 #	10.00 #	10.00 #
Sammaan Capital	8.75 #	8.75 #	8.75 #
Aditya Birla Capital	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
ICICI Home Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Godrej Housing Finance	7.65 #	7.65 #	7.65 #
*Extra 0.05% rate concession to borrowers opting for insurance Rates as on April 29 #onwards Source:Paisabazaar.com			

JERUSALEM

Israel approves fighter jet deal with the U.S. to boost aerial superiority



AFP

Israel on Sunday approved a multi-billion-dollar deal to acquire two combat squadrons of F-35 stealth fighter jets and F-15IA warplanes from the U.S., with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu saying it would “reinforce” its air superiority. Israel’s air force played a key role in the war in Gaza and in the ongoing conflict with Iran. AFP

ASHKELON

Israeli court extends detention of two Gaza-bound flotilla activists



AFP

An Israeli court on Sunday extended by two days the detention of two foreign activists from a Gaza-bound flotilla, who were brought to Israel for questioning, a rights group said. The aid flotilla of more than 50 vessels set sail from France, Spain and Italy but was cut off by Israeli forces in international waters off Greece on Thursday. AFP

OTTAWA

Khalistan extremists declared a ‘national security threat’ by Canada



AFP

Canada has declared Khalistani extremists a “national security threat”, adding that the group uses institutions to promote its “violent extremist agenda” in the country. The report comes a year after the 40th anniversary of the bombing of Air India Flight 182, whose suspects were members of Khalistani extremist groups. PTI

COLOMBO

Sri Lanka arrests 37 Chinese at suspected scam centre, say police



AFP

The Sri Lankan police have arrested 37 Chinese nationals suspected of running a cyberscam centre in the capital Colombo, a spokesperson said on Sunday, in the latest crackdown on foreign-run online fraud. “They had entered the country on tourist visas and were illegally employed,” a spokesperson said. AFP

Sleepless in Tehran as crowds rally behind the flag

The slogan on a wall in Farsi read, *Meydan bashuma, khayabane ba ma*, meaning ‘The battlefield is yours. The streets are ours’; addressed to the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, it was a message to soldiers to focus on the battlefield with ordinary Iranians in control of their homes; the regime change that was spoken of so confidently during the conflict is not visible in Tehran, not in any form

DISPATCH FROM IRAN

Saurabh Shukla
Saurabh Shahi
TEHRAN

Fifty-three-year-old Mulook stood for hours at the same spot in a crowded square holding her phone aloft. Late into the night, its screen displayed two images – one of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was assassinated on February 28 by U.S.-Israeli air strikes, and the other of the new Supreme Leader, Mojtaba Khamenei.

These past 62 days, through the fasting of Ramadan, come rain or cold, she has been among tens of thousands who gather each night at the centre of the Meydan-e Vali Asr in the Iranian capital to express solidarity with their nation amid an ongoing war.

“We will keep coming until Iran has given a befitting reply for the martyrdom of our Supreme Leader,” says Mulook, who lived

through eight years of the war with Iraq. “We supported our leader then. We supported our country then. What is happening now is nothing compared to those eight years.”

Gathering in unity
Meydan in Farsi or *Maidan* in Hindi and Urdu is a gathering ground. Meydan Vali Asr is Tehran’s largest public square, where the city’s radial roads converge from every direction. Friday nights draw the largest crowds here following the evening prayers. The reason is practical, almost cynical. Attacks tend to happen on weekends while U.S. markets open on Monday.

People here understand Donald Trump’s calculations though the American President clearly miscalculated their resilience and nationalism.

Historically, Iranians have gathered in the past here to speak in one voice whenever the need arose. Above the square hung a billboard bearing a caricature of Donald Trump, his

mouth sealed with the image of the Strait of Hormuz and a caption: “At the breaking point”.

The Strait has been cast in Iran’s strategic imagination as a weapon – a chokepoint for the world’s oil supply that Tehran has made no secret of its willingness to use. The billboard was not a threat, but a reminder.

A second slogan on a wall nearby in Farsi read, “*Meydan bashuma, khayabane ba ma*” (The battlefield is yours. The streets are ours). Addressed to the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), it was a message to the soldiers to focus on the battlefield with ordinary Iranians in control of their homes.

‘Look ahead’

People say they do not want the army ‘to worry about what is behind you’, referring to the reports of mass protests against the government earlier in January this year. Iranian authorities called the protests “terror” incidents provoked by pro-American



Vehicles drive past a billboard with graphic showing the Strait of Hormuz and sewn lips of Donald Trump, in Tehran on Saturday. AP

and pro-Israeli elements.

There was a serpentine queue to register when we entered the square to carry a large Iranian national flag aloft at the centre of the gathering. Hundreds of men and women – young and old – waited patiently for their turn, each allotted 10 minutes. A girl, no more than seven or eight, held the flag with a sense of pride, despite the visible effort required to carry the body on Friday, three days after announcing its withdrawal.

Twenty-four hours a

return home so late. “I think this is a duty. I have to come. I have to stand here with other people,” she said not willing to be named.

She was not speaking of ideology but of obligation. The square, for her, was not a political statement so much as a place she felt she had to be. Around her, women with headscarves stood shoulder to shoulder with those without watching visuals of the late Supreme Leader play out on the large screen.

A 63-year-old cleric wearing a long robe lifted a copy of the Koran to his lips choked with tears. Since the war broke out on February 28, he has attended these gatherings every single day in Tehran and beyond. “America wanted to break our confidence, to make us feel weak. I come here to show that we are stronger than before,” he says.

Strong resolve

Last Friday, May 1, also happened to be Iran’s National Teachers’ Day. And a young teacher stood at Meydan until the very end of the night. Her parents, she admitted, were not happy with her decision to

The Iranian tricolour, green, white and red. And the yellow flag of Hezbollah, the Lebanese militant movement and political party that is at war with Israel.

A reminder that Washington and Tel Aviv have failed in many of their objectives cited for justifying this unilateral war. From regime change to weakening the ‘axis of resistance’ (the network of Iran’s allies in the region). To separate Iran from Lebanon, to isolate Hezbollah, to make each front fight alone. Iranians defied again and again.

Nationalist songs, invoking Imam Ali, mixing religious sentiment with pride in the Iranian nation played out loud in signs of shifting sands. Historically, religious identity was primary in Iran’s public life and national identity was secondary.

But last year’s 12-day conflict changed the dynamics. The establishment’s message to the people now reads: “Even if you do not believe in the Islam-

ic Republic, you believe in Iran. Come on that basis. You are welcome here.”

The night does not end

As midnight passed, the square did not thin out. The flag changed hands again and again, the queue replenishing itself sipping cups of Iranian chai. A child slept off against a parent’s shoulder somewhere in the crowd.

When Mr. Trump had said, some weeks ago, that he would “obliterate” their civilisation, people had come to the bridges and the overpasses and stood there in the open. Come then, was the answer. “We are here”.

The regime change that was spoken of so confidently in the early days of this conflict is not visible here, not in any form. What is visible is a city that has decided, for now, that the street is where it needs to be.

Tehran does not sleep any more. (Saurabh Shukla and Saurabh Shahi are senior editors with The Red Mike)

Russia and Ukraine drones kill four, hit ‘shadow fleet’ tankers

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

Russian drone strikes on Ukraine killed three persons across the country, while Ukrainian attacks killed one near Moscow and targeted Russia’s lucrative oil facilities, according to statements by the warring countries on Sunday.

The two neighbours have been firing hundreds of explosive-packed drones at each other on a daily basis throughout the four-year war, as talks to end the conflict have gone nowhere.

Russia fired 268 drones and one ballistic missile in the overnight attack, Kyiv’s Air Force said.

Ukraine’s Army, meanwhile, launched at least 334 drones at Russia, Moscow’s Defence Ministry said.

The northwestern Leningrad region was heavily targeted.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said two of Russia’s so-called shadow tankers – ageing vessels that ferry its sanctioned oil – were struck off the southern Black Sea port of Novorossiysk.

Back to school



Secondary school students wave the Kuwaiti flag as they gather in the grounds of Fajr al-Sabah School in Kuwait City on Sunday to attend in-person classes after these were suspended for more than two months following military strikes by the U.S. and Israel against Iran. AFP

‘U.S. to reduce troops in Germany a lot further than 5,000’

Associated Press
WEST PALM BEACH

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Saturday that the U.S. will significantly reduce its troop presence in Germany, escalating a dispute with Chancellor Friedrich Merz as he seeks to scale back America’s commitment to European security.

The Pentagon on Friday had initially announced it would pull some 5,000 troops out of Germany, but when asked on Saturday about the reason for the move, Mr. Trump didn’t



Donald Trump

offer an explanation and said an even bigger reduction was coming.

“We’re going to cut way down. And we’re cutting a lot further than 5,000,” Mr. Trump told presspersons in Florida.

‘RSF drone strike kills at least five near Sudan capital’

Associated Press
CAIRO

Sudan’s paramilitary group, the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) killed at least five people in a drone attack that hit a civilian vehicle on the outskirts of Khartoum, a local Sudanese rights group said.

Emergency Lawyers condemned the attack and held the RSF responsible. “What happened was a brazen violation of international humanitarian law.”

OPEC+ hikes oil production quotas without mentioning UAE pull-out

Agence France-Presse
VIENNA

Saudi Arabia, Russia and five other OPEC+ countries increased their oil production quota on Sunday in an expected move aimed at demonstrating continuity at the cartel after the shock withdrawal of the United Arab Emirates.

The seven major producers will add 188,000 barrels per day to their total production quota for June amid the price pressure unleashed by the West Asia war, as part of “their



Untapped OPEC+ reserves are mainly located in Gulf region.

collective commitment to support oil market stability”, according to a statement published by OPEC+.

The statement, following an online meeting of Al-

geria, Iraq, Kazakhstan, Kuwait, Oman, Russia and Saudi Arabia, made no mention of the United Arab Emirates, which quit the body on Friday, three days after announcing its withdrawal.

‘Tense relations’

Rystad Energy analyst Jorge Leon said that the silence on the UAE’s departure was a sign of tense relations.

Oil market analysts had widely expected the increase of 188,000 barrels, similar to the 206,000-bar-

rel daily increases OPEC+ announced in both March and April when the portion allotted to the UAE was subtracted.

But raising the quota on paper may not have much impact on actual production, which is already short of the limit.

Untapped OPEC+ reserves are mainly located in the Gulf region, and exports there are trapped by the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, imposed by Iran in response to the U.S.-Israeli strikes since February 28.

Israel strikes south Lebanon, kills one and wounds rescuers

Agence France-Presse
BEIRUT

Israeli strikes on southern Lebanon killed at least one person and wounded four rescuers on Sunday, the Lebanese Health Ministry said, as Israel maintained its attacks on the country despite a fragile truce in its war with Hezbollah.

In separate statements, the Ministry said the a strike on Arabsalim killed at least one person and wounded three, including a child, and another strike on Srifa wounded five per-

Israel issues new evacuation warnings in southern Lebanon for villages beyond the area it occupies

sons including four rescuers from the Hezbollah-affiliated Islamic Health Committee, as the strike hit near one of their centres.

“The Ministry reiterates its condemnation of these repeated attacks and recalls what is included in Article 19 of the Geneva Con-

vention regarding the need to verify that medical facilities are safe from any danger caused by attacks in conflict zones, while what is happening is exactly the opposite.”

Israel’s military on Sunday issued new evacuation warnings in southern Lebanon for villages beyond the area it occupies.

The warning covers more than 10 villages and towns including several in the district of Nabatieh, which lies north of the Litani River, south of which Israel has stationed troops.

KKR'S OWN

Narine first overseas bowler to join 200-wicket club in the IPL



NAGARA GOPAL

▲ Sunil Narine joined the 200-wicket club in the IPL, becoming the third bowler after Yuzvendra Chahal and Bhuvneshwar Kumar to reach the mark. The KKR veteran is the first to achieve the feat with a single franchise. He is the first overseas bowler to enter the elite club. He now has 201 wickets in 197 matches at an average of 25.53.

SKIPPER'S PRIDE

‘Varun is always confident, works very hard and has a great attitude’



NAGARA GOPAL

▲ I'm happy for Varun. He was struggling before the IPL and even in the first couple of games going into the tournament. The way he has come back has been amazing. He is always confident, works hard and has a great attitude. He's been bowling the tough overs. I'm sure he'll continue to shine — KKR skipper Ajinkya Rahane.

MISSED CHANCE

We should've found a way to get around 180 to 200: Cummins



NAGARA GOPAL

▲ We got off to a pretty good start and after that, we weren't at our sharpest. We should've found a way to get around 180 to 200. The wicket did slow up. With the bowling unit, we dragged it right to the end. My over costing 27 runs probably made a difference — SRH captain Pat Cummins.

JOY TO ANGUISH

CSK's Ramakrishna ruled out of the season with foot fracture



B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

▲ Chennai Super Kings' Ramakrishna Ghosh has been ruled out of the tournament after suffering a right foot fracture on his IPL debut on Saturday. Ramakrishna returned figures of one for 24 from three overs, taking the key wicket of Suryakumar Yadav. He is the third CSK player after Khaleel Ahmed and Ayush Mhatre to be ruled out.



Deadly duo: Holder's four-for restricted Kings to 163 for nine before Washington sealed a nervy chase for the home team. VIJAY SONEJI

Holder, Washington star as Titans win a thriller

IPL-19

Abhishek Saini

AHMEDABAD

Gujarat Titans once again took the hard route in pursuing a middling total but avoided a catastrophic middle-order slump by a whisker to claim a four-wicket win over Punjab Kings in IPL 2026 at the Narendra Modi Stadium here on Sunday.

The task of chasing 164 was tailor-made for B. Sai Sudharsan's calibrated approach. He struck a half-century (57, 41b, 5x4, 1x6) and was the constant in neatly-compiled partnerships after the early fall of Shubman Gill.

However, his dismissal in the 15th over left the door open for PBKS to snatch an unlikely win.

If Sai Sudharsan's measured cover drive off Xavier Bartlett in the first over was of the classic mould, the southpaw's ramp off Marco Jansen over short third came from his reserve for the daring.

In dewy conditions, Yuzvendra Chahal was held back till the 14th over and Sai Sudharsan duly grabbed the match-up by pocketing two boundaries off sweep shots. But the game turned on its head after Sai Sudharsan and Rahul Tewatia holed out to deep square leg in similar

fashion off Vyshak and Jansen, respectively.

Jason Holder was snafled at long on in the penultimate over. GT needed to get 11 off the final six balls. It was finally down to Washington Sundar (40 n.o., 23b, 5x4, 1x6) to hold his nerve and end the chase with a lap off a full toss from Marcus Stoinis.

But a nail-biter was the least probable outcome when Suryansh Shedge (57, 29b, 3x4, 5x6) and Stoinis (40, 31b, 5x4, 1x6) were asked to steer PBKS from 47 for five.

Their 79-run sixth-wicket partnership was direly-needed after the visitor's top-order was blown away by the Titans pacers on a green surface. They came up bang for their buck as PBKS managed its lowest PowerPlay score of the season (35 for three).

Mohammed Siraj snared Priyansh Arya and Cooper Connolly off the first three balls of the contest. Rabada bookended the PowerPlay with a wicket- maiden that accounted for Prabhsimran Singh.

PBKS sank further after Shreyas Iyer, who was plotting to navigate the tumultuous period in singles, chopped a length ball from Holder onto his stumps in the ninth over.

But thanks to Shedge, PBKS lived to fight on despite the sloppy start. But it was not enough.

SCOREBOARD

PUNJAB KINGS

Priyansh Arya c Nishant b Siraj 2 (2b), Prabhsimran Singh c Manav b Rabada 15 (14b, 2x4), Cooper Connolly c Buttler b Siraj 0 (1b), Shreyas Iyer b Holder 19 (21b, 3x4), Nehal Wadhwa c Buttler b Holder 0 (6b), Suryansh Shedge c Buttler b Rabada 57 (29b, 3x4, 5x6), Marcus Stoinis c Washington b Holder 40 (31b, 5x4, 1x6), Marco Jansen c Gill b Rashid 20 (11b, 1x4, 1x6), Xavier Bartlett b Holder 0 (1b), V. Vyshak (Impact Player for Wadhwa) (not out) 1 (3b), Arshdeep Singh (not out) 1 (1b); Extras (lb-1, w-7): 8; Total (for nine wkts. in 20 overs): 163.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-2 (Priyansh, 0.2 overs), 2-2 (Connolly, 0.3), 3-35 (Prabhsimran, 5.2), 4-36 (Wadhwa, 6.3), 5-47 (Shreyas, 8.4), 6-126 (Shedge, 15.6), 7-141 (Stoinis, 17.4), 8-141 (Bartlett, 17.5), 9-162 (Jansen, 19.5).

TITANS BOWLING

Siraj 4-0-28-2, Rabada 4-1-22-2, Holder 4-0-24-4, Arshad 3-0-29-0, Rashid 4-0-32-1, Manav 1-0-27-0.

GUJARAT TITANS

Sai Sudharsan c Bartlett b Vyshak 57 (41b, 5x4, 1x6), Shubman Gill c

Connolly b Arshdeep 5 (4b, 1x4), Jos Buttler c Shreyas b Vyshak 26 (22b, 1x4, 2x6), Nishant Sindhu c Vyshak b Stoinis 15 (11b, 1x6), Washington Sundar (not out) 40 (23b, 5x4, 1x6), Rahul Tewatia (Impact Player for Siraj) c Bartlett b Jansen 2 (6b), Jason Holder c Connolly b Arshdeep 5 (7b), Arshad Khan (not out) 8 (5b, 1x4); Extras (lb-2, w-7): 9; Total (for six wkts. in 19.5 overs): 167.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-16 (Gill, 1.3), 2-69 (Buttler, 8.1), 3-94 (Nishant, 11.3), 4-124 (Sai Sudharsan, 14.5), 5-140 (Tewatia, 16.6), 6-152 (Holder, 18.5).

KINGS BOWLING

Bartlett 4-0-38-0, Arshdeep 4-0-24-2, Jansen 4-0-33-1, Vyshak (Impact Player for Wadhwa) 4-0-31-2, Stoinis 2.5-0-26-1, Chahal 1-0-13-0.

Toss: Titans; **PoM:** Holder. Titans won by four wickets with one ball to spare.

Next assignment

PBKS: May 6 vs. SRH Hyderabad, 7.30 p.m.

GT: May 9 vs. RR Jaipur, 7.30 p.m.

Anirudh Velamuri

HYDERABAD

▲ Sunrisers Hyderabad, in quintessential fashion, began its IPL clash against Kolkata Knight Riders with an onslaught so ferocious it felt like the game might be over before it had properly begun. Boundaries flew, the scoreboard spiralled, and KKR was pushed to the brink as SRH went past the 100-run mark in a blink-and-you-miss-it 8.5 overs.

That chaos, stunning and without warning, gave way for a spectacular collapse, courtesy an adamant spin chokehold by Varun Chakravarthy and Sunil Narine that eventually set up a seven-wicket victory for the visitors at the Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium on Sunday.

Travis Head lit up a sweltering afternoon. Four crisp boundaries - threaded through backward point, lofted over point, driven past mid-on, and whipped through square leg - in Vaibhav Arora's opening over put SRH firmly on the front foot.

Despite losing Abhishek Sharma early, the Australian motored on to a blistering half-century off just 22 balls. But Varun had the last laugh, with a mishit promptly landing in Cameron Green's hands at deep midwicket. While SRH eyed another 200-plus score, a stingy KKR happily played spoilsport.

It all began with a sensational one-handed catch by Rovman Powell to dismiss Heinrich Klaasen. From then on, it was a forlorn procession back to the dugout for the home side. The only double ton one witnessed was Narine joining the 200-wickets club, the first overseas bowler to do so in the competition.

Seeing six wickets fall to spin, Pat Cummins opened the defence of a brittle 165 with Abhishek. Finn Allen



Connecting thin air: Salil is bowled neck and crop by Narine. NAGARA GOPAL

SCOREBOARD

SUNRISERS HYDERABAD

Abhishek Sharma c Green b Tyagi 15 (10b, 1x4, 1x6), Travis Head c Green b Varun 61 (28b, 9x4, 3x6), Ishan Kishan c Anukul b Narine 42 (29b, 4x4, 2x6), Heinrich Klaasen c Powell b Green 11 (8b, 1x6), R. Smaran c Rahane b Varun 4 (4b, 1x4), Aniket Verma c Rahane b Varun 6 (8b, 1x4), Salil Arora b Narine 2 (6b), Pat Cummins c & b Anukul 10 (8b, 1x6), Shivang Kumar c Raghuvanshi b Vaibhav 1 (2b), Harshal Patel c Vaibhav b Tyagi 6 (5b, 1x4), Eshan Malinga (not out) 2 (6b); Extras (lb-1, w-4) 5; Total (in 19 overs): 165.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-44 (Abhishek, 3.4 overs), 2-105 (Head, 8.6), 3-117 (Klaasen, 10.4),

4-122 (Smaran, 11.3), 5-135 (Aniket, 13.4), 6-139 (Salil, 15.1), 7-148 (Kishan, 15.6), 8-156 (Cummins, 16.6), 9-156 (Shivang, 17.1).

KNIGHT RIDERS BOWLING

Narine 4-0-31-2, Vaibhav 3-0-25-1, Tyagi 4-0-30-2, Green 3-0-34-1, Varun 4-0-36-3, Anukul 1-0-8-1.

KOLKATA KNIGHT RIDERS

Ajinkya Rahane c Smaran b Sakib 43 (36b, 4x4, 1x6), Finn Allen (Impact Player for Vaibhav) c Klaasen b Cummins 29 (13b, 3x4, 2x6), Angkrish Raghuvanshi c Malinga b Shivang 59 (47b, 5x4, 2x6), Rinku Singh (not out) 22 (11b, 2x4, 1x6), Cameron Green (not out) 3 (3b); Extras (lb-1, w-12): 13; Total (for three wkts. in

18.2 overs): 169.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-49 (Allen, 3.6), 2-133 (Rahane, 14.6), 3-151 (Raghuvanshi, 16.4).

SUNRISERS BOWLING

Abhishek 2-0-14-0, Cummins 4-0-47-1, Malinga 3.2-0-42-0, Shivang 4-0-31-1, Harshal 2-0-17-0, Sakib (Impact Player for Aniket) 3-0-17-1.

Toss: SRH; **PoM:** Varun. KKR won by seven wickets with 10 balls to spare.

Next assignment

SRH: May 6 vs. PBKS Hyderabad, 7.30 p.m.

KKR: May 8 vs. DC Delhi, 7.30 p.m.

Impact Index

1 Holder registered the best figures (4/24) by a GT bowler against PBKS

3 At the age of 24, Sai Sudharsan (18 in 50 innings) has the third-most half-centuries after Gill (24, 100) and Jaiswal (20, 76)

4 Narine bowled the first over of an innings for the fourth time in the IPL, the previous one in 2020

6 Narine and Varun combined to take five or

more wickets in an innings for the sixth time

7 Head's 50-plus scores as an opener at a strike-rate of 200-plus. Only Warner (9) and Gayle (8) have more

18 Number of wickets GT has taken in the PowerPlay this season, the third-best after RR (21) and RCB (19)

19 Pandey joined Kohli and Rohit in the list of players to figure in every season of the league

Compiled by ANIRUDH VELAMURI

Teen sensation Antonelli completes hat-trick

FORMULA ONE

Sports Bureau

Mercedes' teen sensation Andrea Kimi Antonelli held his nerve under intense pressure from reigning champion Lando Norris to clinch his third career Grand Prix victory in an action-packed Miami Grand Prix on Sunday.

The 19-year-old has now made it a hat-trick of wins this season and extended his championship lead over teammate George Russell to 20 points.

McLaren's Norris, who briefly led the race, had to



Making history: Antonelli has become the first driver to win his first three races from pole position. AP

settle for second.

The second McLaren of Oscar Piastri clinched the final podium position, getting past Ferrari's Charles Leclerc in the penultimate

lap of the race.

The results (58/58):

1. Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes); 2. Lando Norris (McLaren); 3. Oscar Piastri (McLaren); 4. George

Russell (Mercedes); 5. Max Verstappen (Red Bull Racing); 6. Charles Leclerc (Ferrari); 7. Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari); 8. Franco Colapinto (Alpine); 9. Carlos Sainz (Williams); 10. Alexander Albon (Williams); 11. Ollie Bearman (Haas); 12. Gabriel Bortoletto (Audi); 13. Esteban Ocon (Haas); 14. Arvid Lindblad (RB Formula One Team); 15. Fernando Alonso (Aston Martin); 16. Sergio Perez (Cadillac F1 Team); 17. Lance Stroll (Aston Martin); 18. Valtteri Bottas (Cadillac).
DNF: Nico Hulkenberg (Audi), Liam Lawson (RB), Pierre Gasly (Alpine), Isack Hadjar (Red Bull).
Standings: Drivers: 1. Antonelli 100; 2. Russell 80; 3. Leclerc 63; 4. Norris 51; 5. Hamilton 49.
Constructors: 1. Mercedes 180; 2. Ferrari 112; 3. McLaren 94; 4. Red Bull Racing 26; 5. Haas 17.

Shayan Acharya

MUMBAI

Mumbai Indians has long built a reputation as masters of the turnaround, a side that has repeatedly defied the odds to lift the IPL trophy a record five times.

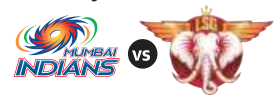
This season, however, has been a different story. The star-studded lineup has managed just two wins from nine outings, leaving it on the brink of elimination. While mathematical possibilities of a playoff berth remain, the equation is unforgiving: win every remaining game and rely on favourable results elsewhere.

Even that fragile hope could unravel quickly. A defeat against Lucknow Super Giants at the Wankhede Stadium on Monday would extinguish any chance of a late resurgence.

Despite boasting some of the biggest names in Indian cricket, MI has struggled across departments. Captain Hardik Pandya (146 runs in eight innings) and Suryakumar Yadav have lacked consistency, the latter has managed just 183 runs in nine innings, including a solitary fifty.

Coming off a stellar campaign last year, where he amassed over 700 runs, expectations were high.

Today's match



Mumbai, 7.30 p.m.
HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 8
MI 2 | LSG 6

PREVIOUS MEETING
MI won by 54 runs, 2025

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIOHOTSTAR

However, Suryakumar has been troubled by hard-length deliveries, a key factor behind his lean run this season. Batting issues are worsened by Rohit Sharma's absence with a hamstring injury. Rohit, though, trained on Sunday.

Pace spearhead Jasprit Bumrah has been off-colour.

Things have not been much better for LSG.

The bowlers, led by pacers Mohammed Shami and Mohsin Khan, have put up a fighting show. However, the batting has faltered as partnerships have been rare, and PowerPlay returns inconsistent. Captain Rishabh Pant has struggled for form, further compounding the woes.

On paper, it is a clash between two bottom-ranked sides, but when they meet, pride will be at stake along with a fading hope of a miracle.

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Punjab Kings	9	6	2	1	13	0.855
Royal Challengers	9	6	3	0	12	1.420
Sunrisers Hyderabad	10	6	4	0	12	0.644
Rajasthan Royals	10	6	4	0	12	0.510
Gujarat Titans	10	6	4	0	12	-0.147
Chennai Super Kings	9	4	5	0	8	0.005
Delhi Capitals	9	4	5	0	8	-0.895
Kolkata Knight Riders	9	3	5	1	7	-0.539
Mumbai Indians	9	2	7	0	4	-0.803
Lucknow Super Giants	8	2	6	0	4	-1.106

South Korean women dethrone China

UBER CUP

Sports Bureau

South Korean women stunned China to reclaim the Uber Cup, for the first time in four years, after a 3-1 victory in the summit clash at Horsens on Sunday. Korea won its third

crown after the triumphs in 2010 and 2022.

The results: Uber Cup: Final: South Korea bt China 3-1 (An Se-young bt Wang Zhi Yi 21-10, 21-13; Lee So-hee & Jeong Na-eun lost to Liu Sheng Shu and Tan Nin 15-21, 12-21; Kim Ga-eun bt Chen Yu Fei 21-19, 21-15; Kim Hye-jeong & Baek Ha-na bt Jia Yi Fan & Zhang Shu Xian 16-21, 21-10, 21-13.

Dhoni reality check — what the Super Kings faithful dreaded

The bond between the legendary captain of the franchise and the legion of fans goes beyond trophies and silverware; the supporters are beginning to get a glimpse of life beyond the gloveman though they would be keen to celebrate a cameo or two from Captain Cool



R. Kaushik

For those who love yellow, Chepauk is heaven on earth when Chennai Super Kings come calling. All roads leading up to the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium in the Tamil Nadu capital are draped in an endless sea of yellow, the colour of the franchise which has won the Indian Premier League a joint record five times. On match days, thousands flock the venue, trooping in by various modes of transport, proudly wearing the team's jersey, blowing yellow whistles with abandon and waving the franchise flag uninhibitedly.

Every match evening, a ritual that precedes the arrival of the buses carrying the players to the ground. Outside Gate No. 2 on the Victoria Hostel Road, through which the buses of both the home and the away outfits enter the stadium premises, Leo, the affable mascot, is joined by numerous drum-beating individuals who summon admirable intensity in the extreme humidity, their efforts peaking to a crescendo as the buses near the entry gate. 'Snake bombs' emitting yellow smoke add to the drama, the acrid, pungent smell causing throats to burn and eyes to tear up, but that doesn't stop hundreds from whipping out their cell phones and capturing videos for posterity, even though they are often greeted by walled up windows and therefore no sighting of their heroes.

When CSK were suspended from the IPL for two years and Dhoni went to RPS, he made it clear that his heart didn't exactly bleed for his temporary home

everyone will immediately be able to remember what Jasprit Bumrah's jersey number (93) is. But like No. 10 (Sachin Tendulkar), No. 18 (Virat Kohli) and No. 45 (Rohit Sharma), No. 7 leaves no scope for doubt or argument, no need for that extra fraction of a second to figure out who dons that famous number.

Just for extra help, No. 7 is sub-texted by 'Dhoni'. Five letters which, when placed in that sequence, drive the passionate, respectful and knowledgeable CSK fans into a frenzy, forcing them to suspend belief and to convince themselves that impossible is nothing.

Impossible truly was nothing - or was nothing truly impossible? - when Mahendra Singh Dhoni was at his peak, which was for an incredibly long time. His evolution from long-haired muscled to a more nuanced finisher is a story too well documented to bear extensive repetition. While he was making waves internationally with his calmness under pressure, his wondrous decision-making abilities and his extraordinary swiftness behind the stumps, Dhoni came to represent an emotion in Chennai, seeming singularly unprepared for the unprecedented Dhoni wave that has left thousands in rhapsody and delirium.

An emotional bond

It didn't take Dhoni long to win over the affections of the Chennai millions. What appeared a mismatch - suave, slow-paced, reverential Chennai and a rustic Jharkhandi with a love for fast bikes

and fast bowling - became a match for the ages. Dhoni stormed the consciousness of the average Chennaitte with his organic charm and his uncommon propensity to be himself instead of feeling the pressure to conform to norms. The bond didn't need victories and titles to become unbreakable, but five title runs didn't hurt.

Dhoni took CSK to the top of the IPL podium for the first time in 2010 and pulled off an encore in 2011. By the second of those triumphs, he had a near full set of international accomplishments as captain - the T20 World Cup Trophy, the No. 1 Test ranking and the 50-over World Cup crown. Two years later, he would add the Champions Trophy to the kitty. Dhoni wasn't just Captain Cool, he was Skipper Superlative, Leader Loved.

When CSK were suspended for the IPL for two years and Dhoni went to Rising Pune Supergiant(s), Dhoni made it clear that his heart didn't exactly bleed for his temporary home. He was desperate to return to Chennai, to the warm embrace of the franchise and its adoring, uncomplaining fans. When, on the eve of CSK's return to the IPL in 2018, Dhoni shed tears in a rare public show of emotion, thousands wept. When he capped a fairytale comeback with a third title in 2018, they wept again - tears of joy and gratitude, of redemption and vindication. CSK's supporters hadn't taken kindly to the suspension owing to the infractions of one of their owners; Dhoni had helped salvage pride and self-respect, character traits that Chennaites and, by extension, the franchise's followers, value immensely.

Further triumphs in 2021 and 2023 merely added to the Dhoni aura. By the fourth title run, Dhoni had officially announced his retirement from international cricket, more than two years after playing his last match for the country on 10 July 2019, the semifinal loss to New Zealand in the 50-over World Cup. But the yellove still burned bright in him, and he wasn't going anywhere.

Every season for the last five or so years has ended with the fear that Dhoni had played his last competitive fixture. Every March, those fears have been laid to rest with Dhoni checking into Chennai to begin/further his preparations for another tilt at the most coveted non-international silverware in men's cricket. He has thought little of going under the knife to address niggling knee issues so that he can extend his IPL career, further endearing himself to the vast legions who simply can't imagine a CSK without Dhoni in the playing mix.

Now, however, one suspects, the fans are beginning to come to terms with the fact that nothing in life is permanent, not even Dhoni in CSK colours as a player. When the CSK bus trailing escort vehicles turned left at Gate No. 2 on Saturday evening, 'Dhoni, Dhoni, Dhoni' rent the air like they have been for the last 18 years. Little did those who were screaming their lungs out realise that the object of their affection, admiration and adulation wasn't on the bus, still to recover from the calf injury that has compelled him to miss the first nine games of the ongoing campaign.

Diminishing returns

Dhoni's returns with the bat have been dropping over the last six years, perfectly understandable given that he is not just a

One suspects that the fans are beginning to come to terms with the fact that nothing in life is permanent, not even Dhoni in CSK colours as a player

one-format player but also that he is now only a one-tournament competitor. Apart from a standout run in 2024 when he struck 13 sixes from his 73 balls faced to rack up a strike-rate of 220.55 to go with an average of 53.67 (boosted by eight not outs in 11 innings), Dhoni has been in the wars. From 2020, the first IPL he entered after playing his last match for India, his strike-rates have read 116.27, 106.54 (2021), 123.40 (2022), 182.46 (2023, when he faced just 57 balls in 12 innings) and 135.17 (2025). Some of the aura began to dim with those thinking with their heads rather than their hearts questioning his very late entry point and using that as an acknowledgement on Dhoni's part that he too believed his best was well behind him.

In a little over two months' time, Dhoni will turn 45 - 30 years older than the newest sensation from the same state in which Dhoni was born in July 1981. Unlike Ranchi-born Dhoni, who played for Jharkhand after Bihar's bifurcation, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi hails from Tajpur, a town in Samastipur district, and represents Bihar in domestic cricket. Sooryavanshi and Dhoni have yet to lock horns - the young lad hadn't made his Rajasthan Royals debut when the teams met in Guwahati in March last year - and may not do so this year either unless the sides meet in the playoffs, which is a shame because, well, because we all know why...

In some ways, it appears as if CSK are gradually beginning to comprehend what life without (after?) Dhoni looks like. This prolonged nine-game absence was clearly unplanned; Dhoni's preparation was well on track until he picked up a calf strain days before the start of the tournament, and when he finally seemed to shrugged that off came a fresh setback, which means that more than halfway through their campaign, Dhoni has yet to take the field - often, he hasn't even arrived at the ground.

It hasn't been smooth sailing, needless to say, but CSK are still in the hunt following Saturday's eight-wicket drubbing of a beleaguered Mumbai Indians which has pushed them up to sixth spot with eight points from nine matches. They perhaps need to double that tally in the remaining five fixtures to be in the playoff race, a tall ask but not necessarily beyond them because finally, after several misses, they are beginning to rack up a few hits. Blighted by injuries (including to left-arm pacer Khaleel Ahmed), they are just about hitting on the right balance to their playing XI, with skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad's return to run-making ways during his Player-of-the-Match-winning effort on Saturday one of the most positive developments for them in recent times.

Sporting crowd

Chepauk on Saturday lived up to its reputation of being a sporting crowd. It cheered on Bumrah and Hardik Pandya and Suryakumar Yadav vociferously, and was generous in its applause when Naman Dhir brought up a stylish half-century.

The loudest roars for the Mumbai camp were reserved for Rohit Sharma, still to recover from a hamstring injury that's rendered him *hors de combat*, but even that paled into insignificance when Ruturaj tried to speak at the toss, when Sanju Samson walked out to take guard in the quest for 160 and two points, and when young Kartik Sharma brought up his maiden half-century.

Dhoni wasn't entirely forgotten - sporadic and sudden shouts of 'Dhoni, Dhoni' rang around the stands - but one got the sense that his giant shadow no longer eclipsed all else CSK. One could sense optimism and the promise of a new beginning among the teeming thousands more than resignation at the possible end of Dhoni's playing days, which perhaps is a first for the multitudes that have hero-worshipped Dhoni to the exclusion of all else. Dhoni owes them a cameo or two in the next few weeks. He has taken Chennai to heart as much as they have him. Don't rule out a final flourish, one last sting in the tail with welcome ramifications, because without intending to be, Dhoni is a showman supreme, failing memory or not. Oh, what fun that will be.

THE GIST

Every season for the last five or so years has ended with the fear that Dhoni had played his last competitive fixture. Every March, those fears have been laid to rest with Dhoni checking into Chennai to begin/further his preparations for another tilt at the most coveted non-international silverware in men's cricket

Dhoni's returns with the bat have been dropping over the last six years, perfectly understandable given that he is not just a one-format player but also that he is now only a one-tournament competitor

Dhoni... when will he swing back into action? R. RAGU



How dual-use satellites are blurring the lines of modern space war

The Outer Space Treaty of 1967 and international humanitarian law require warring parties to differentiate between civilian objects and military targets; however, modern satellites are dual-use by default as civilian GPS networks, broadband constellations routinely support intelligence gathering and drone targeting

Shrawani Shagun

When we imagine space warfare, we picture shattered satellites and orbital debris. The reality is quieter but also more dangerous. The markers of modern orbital conflict are signal loss, deliberate misdirection, and sudden system failures.

In the initial hours of Russia’s invasion of Ukraine in 2022, a cyber-attack crippled Viasat’s KA-SAT network, severing vital communications across Europe. GPS spoofing incidents have similarly misled civilian aircraft and maritime vessels, luring ships into hazardous shoals or corrupting flight computers to trigger false terrain alerts effectively weaponising a platform’s own safety logic against its operators.

The next conflict in space will begin with silence, with jammed signals, altered coordinates, and compromised systems. Space is today critical infrastructure and vulnerabilities related to space are often tantamount vulnerabilities in human society.

This vulnerability is built into the architecture of space systems. Interference leaves no physical trace yet it can be devastating. It operates using three tools: jamming (or blocking signals), spoofing (sending false data), and ground station hacking (taking control of satellite systems).

As a result, no physical destruction is needed to paralyse an adversary – which is an important shift in the way conflict plays out in orbit. As financial, energy, and communication networks depend on satellites, such intrusions can also trigger cascading failures on the earth.

Legal blindspot

This change exposes a deeper legal problem. As the Prussian military theorist Carl von Clausewitz observed, war is defined by its effects. If cyber operations can disable satellites that support power grids, financial systems or emergency communications, their consequences are indistinguishable from a physical strike. However, the United Nations Charter does not clearly address cyber operations within its Article 2(4) prohibition on the “use of force”.

A functional, effects-based test is therefore essential to interpret “use of force” in the orbital domain. As of 2026, several states have moved to the position that a cyber operation does not require physical ‘smoke and fire’ to violate Article 2(4). Instead, if a digital intrusion functionally disables a satellite, effectively bricking it, the strategic and economic consequences are identical to a kinetic strike. In this context, loss of functionality is the new shattered glass.

However, it also comes with a challenge, called the attribution gap. Under the International Law Commission framework on state responsibility, legal



Conflict in orbit no longer requires satellites to be physically destroyed in order to paralyse an adversary. IMAGE CREATED WITH CHATGPT

liability is contingent on identifying the perpetrator with high evidentiary certainty. In the digital domain, operations routed through proxy networks and spoofed identities create a layer of strategic anonymity that complicates traditional deterrence.

This is less a technical flaw and more a structural tension: as long as evidentiary standards are based on visible, physical proof, the invisible nature of cyber-disruption will continue to offer a significant strategic advantage to aggressors. In other words, existing international law recognises force by its consequences – yet it remains in a reactive posture as both the act and the actor remain obscured.

Collapse of civilian-military divide

The legal protections designed to safeguard non-combatants are deteriorating in the face of modern technology. The Outer Space Treaty and international humanitarian law rely heavily on the principle of distinction, requiring warring parties to differentiate between civilian objects and military targets.

However, modern satellites are dual-use by default. Civilian GPS networks, commercial broadband constellations, and financial timestamping systems now routinely support intelligence gathering and drone targeting. Because militaries piggyback on commercial infrastructure, these assets often lose their protected civilian status under international humanitarian law.

That said, in practice, the ‘civilian satellite’ is becoming a legal fiction. When commercial constellations provide ‘space

States must move from advisory norms to enforceable ‘secure-by-design’ standards, clarify when cyber operations in space constitute a use of force, and strengthen cooperative attribution mechanisms. Without this, ambiguity will continue to favour the attacker

as a service’ for military kill-chains – also known as the Starlink Precedent – they dissolve the distinction entirely. In this environment, an entire network can become a legitimate grey-zone target, even if it simultaneously serves schools or hospitals.

Former British army officer and author Emile Simpson has distinguished between traditional Clausewitzian war and contemporary conflict: the former seeks a definitive military decision while the latter functions as a direct instrument of political communication aimed at fragmented audiences.

In space, cyber operations enable ambiguous, deniable attacks that are designed to shape perceptions of state power rather than to secure territorial gains. Because they avoid the debris and visibility of kinetic strikes, they incentivise constant, low-level disruption. This creates a persistent state of friction that never crosses the threshold of war but continuously undermines the political legitimacy of the targeted state.

For India, the 2026 CERT-In/SIA-India Guidelines institutionalised a “secure-by-design” doctrine for space systems. They embed cybersecurity into

every stage of the satellite lifecycle, from design and launch to in-orbit operations and decommissioning. They also identify threats such as signal jamming, spoofing, and unauthorised command access, and recommend layered safeguards across space, ground, and communication segments. However, an enforcement gap remains: India is expanding its presence in orbit faster than it is building the ability to detect and trace cyberattacks in real time.

Objective of disruption

The response cannot remain reactive. States must move from advisory norms to enforceable “secure-by-design” standards, clarify when cyber operations in space constitute a use of force, and strengthen cooperative attribution mechanisms. Without this, ambiguity will continue to favour the attacker. In a digital battlefield, if an attacker cannot be identified within minutes, they cannot be deterred at all.

For the Global South, this digital battlefield poses the unique threat of orbital dependency. When the digital backbones of developing economies are hosted on third-party commercial constellations, a silent strike can blind a military and, more importantly, effectively paralyse a state’s ability to govern, disenfranchising a nation in a single digital stroke.

In this new era, the objective is no longer to destroy a satellite but to disrupt the society that depends on it.

(Shrawani Shagun is a researcher focusing on environmental sustainability and space governance. shrawani.shagun@gmail.com)

THE GIST

▼ The markers of modern orbital conflict are signal loss, deliberate misdirection, and sudden system failures

▼ As financial, energy, and communication networks depend on satellites, such intrusions can also trigger cascading failures on the earth

▼ This change exposes a deeper legal problem. The United Nations Charter does not clearly address cyber operations within its Article 2(4) prohibition on the ‘use of force’

BIG SHOT



Samples of coral collected from the Abrolhos National Marine Park in Brazil on April 23, 2026. The Abrolhos reefs are the most biodiverse coral ecosystem in the South Atlantic. Their biodiversity has dropped by around 15% over 18 years due to marine heatwaves, a new study has found. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Sustainable mining: oxymoron?

Vasudevan Mukunth

Humans are trying to build a low-carbon future. Ironically, this future won’t be possible without mining today. This is because wind turbines, solar panels, and electric batteries all require lithium, cobalt, copper, and rare-earth elements.

Mining doesn’t leave the earth intact. Instead, it extracts finite, non-renewable resources. The processes of mining also often pollute the environment, permanently change landscapes, and destroy biodiversity. So in a commonsensical way, mining is not sustainable. No amount of money or technologies can bring back, say, a pristine rainforest.

However, some people, including the UN and the International Energy Agency, have floated an idea called ‘weak sustainability’ with regards to mining. They argue that mines can be ‘sustainable’ if the extracted resources create greater value, like human capital — like education and infrastructure — that outlasts the mine. They have also said that green technologies of the future make mining inescapable today.

There is a related concept called ‘sustainable mining’. The minerals we



Mining is not sustainable in a commonsensical reading of the word. ABDULL BASIT/UNSPLASH

remove from the ground don’t grow back. But once we start using them, we need to recycle them almost indefinitely. The problem is that the current recycling rate for critical minerals is at best 5%.

Industries have also adopted a framework called ‘responsible mining’, where the focus is on using green hydrogen as fuel for trucks, solar and wind power for mining equipment, and seeking the permission of local communities to operate and sharing profits with them, among others.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Appointments cancelled by Nepal government

1,500 Nepal's new government has effectively cancelled more than 1,500 major public appointments through a sweeping ordinance issued by President Ram Chandra Paudel, local media reported. These appointments were made before March 26 — the date marking leadership change in the country. PTI

Foreign nationals arrested in Sri Lanka for cyber fraud

130 More than 130 foreign nationals were arrested in Sri Lanka for alleged cybercrime operations over the last two days, police said. The police actions are part of a wider crackdown on cross-border online fraud networks operating from the island nation. In a raid in Thalangama, a suburb of Colombo, the police arrested 37 Chinese nationals on Saturday. PTI

Coal imported in Meghalaya without valid papers

3 lakh metric tonnes. Two cement companies in Meghalaya have been accused of violating prescribed norms, a High Court-appointed committee said in its report. The single-member panel of retired judge B. P. Katakay said that they transported the dry fuel from outside between February 2025 and February this year “without obtaining mandatory approvals under the SOP, 2024”. PTI

Number of IPS officers transferred in a major reshuffle in M.P.

62 In a major reshuffle, the Madhya Pradesh government on Sunday transferred 62 IPS officers, including 19 Superintendents of Police, assigning new roles from Additional Director General to Deputy Commissioner of police levels. The Home department transferred Manish Khatri, Singrauli SP, posting him as Assistant Inspector General at the police headquarters in Bhopal. PTI

Kerala's voter turnout after inclusion of service voters' ballots

79.70 per cent. Kerala's voter turnout in the April 9 Assembly elections has tentatively risen to 79.70% after the inclusion of service voters' postal ballots, CEO Rathan U. Kelkar said on Sunday. He also outlined elaborate arrangements for the counting of votes scheduled for Monday. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Rationalising Iran’s nuclear capability

How does the NPT regulate nuclear programmes? Why is uncertainty about nuclear intent a problem? Why does Iran say its nuclear programme is peaceful? Why has the international community sanctioned the country? Can Iran's stance on nuclear weapons change?

EXPLAINER

Vasudevan Mukunth

The story so far:

Under pressure from U.S. President Donald Trump to abandon its nuclear programme, Iran has “vowed” to protect its nuclear stockpile. At the same time, former supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei disapproved of the use of nuclear weapons on religious grounds. How does Iran reconcile the two positions?

What does the NPT allow and restrict?

The Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons – NPT for short – discourages countries from developing nuclear weapons, but does not prevent them from developing the ability to make these weapons. This is ostensibly because some of the same technologies and processes are necessary in a civilian nuclear programme, such as generating nuclear power and making nuclear isotopes for medical use. But the NPT does not turn a blind eye altogether: it expects the civilian programme to include some safeguards that resist the ability to develop from becoming the possession of a nuclear weapon. Examples of such safeguards include closely monitoring the use of technologies like uranium enrichment and plutonium reprocessing.

This said, even these safeguards are focused on diversion, which is only one of the two pieces of the gap between ability and possession, the other being capability. That is, a country can have the capability to develop a nuclear weapon, but the NPT’s safeguards have been designed to deter the diversion of that capability to military uses. Countries interested in helping tame the spread of nuclear weapons have enforced this fuzzy barrier using export controls and diplomacy, including sanctions. The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) contributes as an independent watchdog that performs intrusive inspections.

Why is not knowing a country’s nuclear intent a problem?

This is one way the world has kept itself from downsliding into nuclear catastrophe. It is a fragile setup because the regulatory regime decision focusing on weaponisation rather than capability has created important downsides. Perhaps foremost among them is the threshold state: a country that learns about and builds everything required to make a nuclear weapon but stops just short of building one. This country may also strategise its breakout – the rapid sequence of events from enriching weapons-grade fissile material to deploying a nuclear warhead. This way, the country does not draw sanctions, but the moment its policy changes, it can ‘breakout’ quickly. North Korea was once an example of a threshold state – and now so is Iran.

Not knowing whether a country will actually build nuclear weapons, especially since it has the ability to do so, is also bad for the non-proliferation regime for a few reasons. When a country breaks out, the regime will be forced to respond very close to weaponisation, which may warrant drastic measures, which does not bode well to limit escalation. Second, a non-nuclear-capable country has to guess whether another country – perhaps a neighbour – intends to build nuclear



A child holds an Iranian flag through the window of a vehicle in northern Tehran, Iran, on May 1. AP

weapons. Figuring it out requires judgment, diplomacy, and acting in good faith, all of which are powerful but hard to enforce using external pressure. It also muddies international waters. For example, South Korea does not view Japan with suspicion but it may not extend the same courtesy to, say, Argentina.

Another consequence is the nuclear cascade: if Country A is a threshold state and is not on good terms with its neighbours, the neighbouring countries may find it necessary to arm themselves with nuclear weapons in case Country A decides to break out. This is why the world has clusters of nuclear-capable states: South Asia, West Asia, North America, and Eastern Europe.

How close is Iran to a nuclear weapon?

Iran joined the NPT in 1970 but has recently expressed doubts about its participation. It is also a threshold state with a breakout time widely understood to be in the order of a few weeks. It is also thought to possess around 500 kg of uranium enriched to 60%. According to *The New York Times*, in fact, Iran possesses 11 tonnes of uranium overall enriched anywhere from 2% to 60%. Nuclear power reactors require uranium enriched to significantly under 20%. Weapons-grade uranium requires 90%. The way enrichment works, the road from 60% to 90% is much shorter than getting to 60%. In other words, Iran is for all practical purposes a nuclear-capable state – yet it is not known to have developed a nuclear weapon.

Ayatollah Ali Khamenei spoke against using nuclear weapons, calling them ‘haram’. Many have claimed that he issued a *fatwa* – a ruling based on Islamic law – against the nuclear bomb. Tehran has held that its stockpile and nuclear infrastructure are “peaceful” and

intended for civilian use. This is technically possible because uranium enriched to 20% or more can be transformed in a process called downblending to a lower enrichment and used for civilian purposes. The NPT also treats the use of nuclear technologies for scientific progress as every country’s “inalienable right”.

Iran’s claims to that end were also politically credible as it abided by the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), a.k.a. the Iran deal, until Mr. Trump unilaterally exited it in 2018. In effect, Mr. Trump sought to back Iran into a corner, which backfired after Tehran took licence from Israel’s aggression across West Asia to resume higher enrichment.

Despite the Joe Biden administration’s attempts to restore parts of the deal, Iran progressively scaled back its commitments under the JCPOA. In Islamic jurisprudence, Iran has a valorous duty to defend its homeland against “Zionist” aggression – which includes defending its enrichment sites and, by appealing to its right to scientific progress, its nuclear stockpile as well.

Why are the regulatory options limited?

These reasons alone have not convinced the international community, however, much of which agrees Iran is a threshold state. The UN Security Council, the U.S., and the European Union have sanctioned Iran pre-2015 over Tehran’s failure to declare uranium particles the IAEA found at three undeclared sites and the related past uranium processing activities, as required by its safeguards agreement with the IAEA.

Today, Iran’s stockpile and the extent and sophistication of its nuclear infrastructure are believed to mean its breakout time could be short – yet the non-proliferation regime has limited

courses of action because Tehran is technically toeing the line.

The U.S. and Israel have nonetheless repeatedly gone to war against Iran because they are nervous and want to eliminate even its status as a threshold state. This includes the ongoing conflict as well as the Twelve-Day War last year, and attempts over the years to assassinate Iranian nuclear scientists and mount covert attacks, such as the Stuxnet virus in the late 2000s.

How did the Iran-Iraq war shape Iran’s stance?

In fact, the fatwa is also not necessarily binding, thanks to a policy called *Maslahat-e-Nizam*, meaning ‘expediency of the system’. Specifically, in Shia Islam, a fatwa is not necessarily eternal but can be a ruling based on existing circumstances. If those circumstances change, so can the decision. Since the threats to Iran from Israel and the U.S. have been deemed existential of late – a point the U.S. has been happy to parrot as part of its brinkmanship – the Supreme Leader, currently Mojtaba Khamenei, could supersede his predecessor’s diktat.

In the post-revolution era, Iran’s leadership has been opposed to nuclear weapons on religious or ethical grounds because of the country’s experiences during and after the Iran-Iraq war (1980-1988). In the early and mid-1980s, Iraq deployed chemical weapons against Iranian soldiers as well as civilians, killing tens of thousands. The Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini famously resisted retaliating in kind, appealing to his religion forbidding indiscriminate killing and securing a moral victory for his regime.

But Tehran revived its interest in the nuclear programme after officials argued that the international community, including the UN, had however failed to respond adequately to Iraq’s use of chemical weapons.

THE GIST

Iran is a “threshold state”; it has the capability to develop nuclear weapons and a short breakout time, but has not moved to possession.

The NPT allows civilian nuclear programmes but seeks to prevent diversion to military use, creating a gap between ability and weaponisation.

Iran maintains its programme is “peaceful” and within its rights, even as sanctions, uncertainty, and limited options define the global response.

